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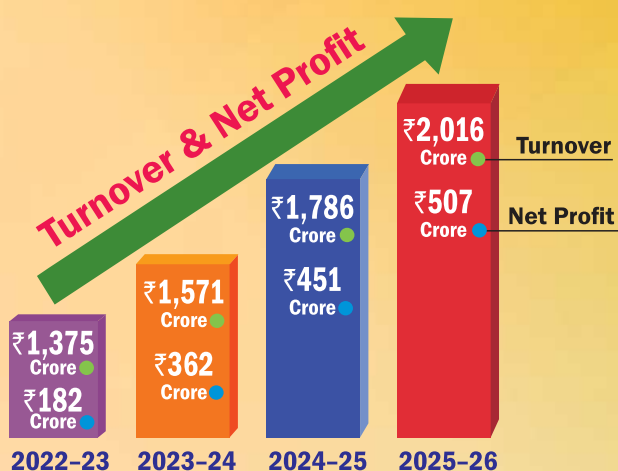


Shri D. K. Shivakumar
Hon'ble Deputy Chief Minister
Government of Karnataka

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Shri M.B. Patil, Hon'ble Minister for Large & Medium Industries and Infrastructure Development, and Shri Appaji C.S. Nadagouda, Hon'ble MLA & Chairman, KS&DL, presenting Mysore Sandal products to Hon'ble Chief Minister Shri Siddaramaiah

**KS&DL
achieves
an all-time
record in 2025-26**

₹2,016 Crore
Turnover

₹507 Crore
Net Profit

₹150 Crore
Dividend to the govt.
A significant leap
from **21st to 1st** in
dividend contribution
to the Govt.

47,494 MT
Production

57 New Products

Increase in Exports

Organising the 'Mysore Sandal Soap Mela' across the state

Sandalwood cultivation expansion

**700+ Farmers,
3,800+ Acres**



**From ₹1,000 crore in 105 years
to ₹2,000 crore in just FOUR years
KS&DL's growth story redefined**

KSDL Profit Growth: 35% CAGR over the past 5 years

The historic achievement in production, turnover and profit has been realised by enhancing efficiency without adding new machinery or increasing the workforce.

**New targets set by
Hon'ble Minister Shri M.B. Patil**

Reaching a turnover of ₹3,000 crore by 2028
and ₹5,000 crore by 2030.

Awards and honours received by KS&DL

- | | |
|---|---|
|  <p>Nadaprabhu Kempegowda International Award 2025
from the state government
for KSE&DL's remarkable
achievements</p> |  <p>Excellence in CSR 2025
Award from the Directorial
Advisors Consortium (DAC)</p> |
|  <p>Best CEO 2025 Award
from IIMM</p> |  <p>Best Emerging State PSU 2025
Award by News18 Network</p> |



Ms. Tamannaah Bhatia, a leading name in the Indian film industry with a strong pan-India presence and over 3 crore social media followers, has been appointed as the brand ambassador of Mysore Sandal Soap.

A big thank you to all the workers, unions, staff, officers,
General Manager - Administration, General Manager - Finance, for their valuable
contributions to this stupendous achievement of the organisation.



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Dr. S. Selvakumar, IAS, Principal Secretary
Department of Industries & Commerce

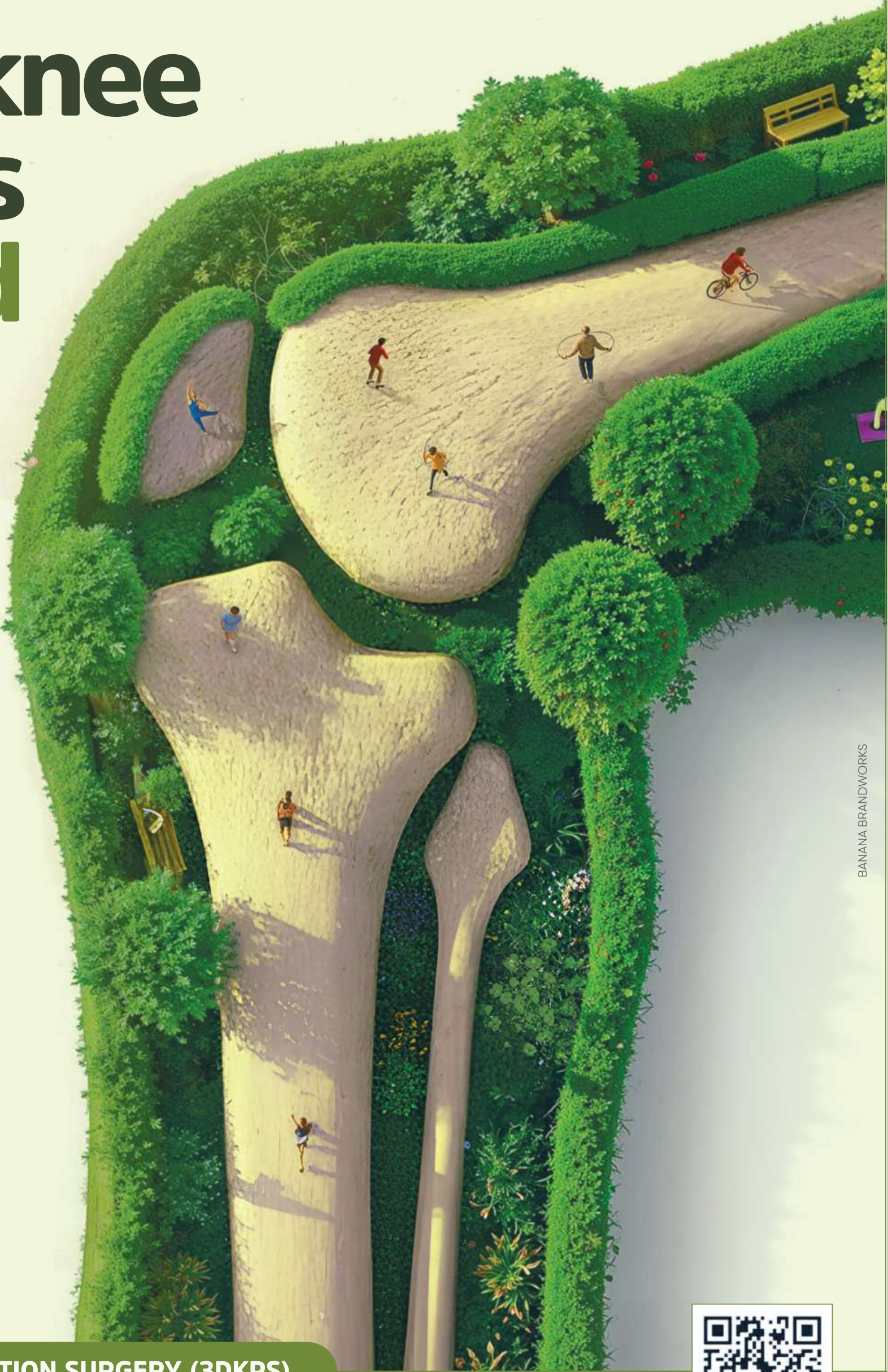
Dr. Prashaanth P.K.M., IFS, Managing Director
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PM calls Ganga Expressway identity of 'new U.P.'
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Increased imports buoy natural gas stock
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Tamil Nadu's growth record
Manufacturing sector remains the principal driver of growth
OPINION » PAGE 11

CLINICAL CHASE
Sunrisers Hyderabad routs Mumbai Indians
SPORT » PAGE 17

NEARBY



T.N. govt. rejects contention on Cauvery water

CHENNAI
The State government on Wednesday rejected Karnataka's contention that the surplus water released to Tamil Nadu during 2025-26 should be taken into consideration for the monthly schedule. » PAGE 8

Hindu couple made guardian of Muslim child

MADURAI
Considering the welfare of a Muslim child, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has appointed a Hindu couple as the child's legal guardian. A Bench took into account that the couple had taken care of the child right from birth. » PAGE 8

Kalhatti Ghat Road closed to tourists

UDHAGAMANDALAM
The Nilgiris district administration has announced the closure of the Kalhatti Ghat Road to tourist vehicles with immediate effect. The move follows a Madras High Court order, seeking to control the flow of traffic into the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve (MTR). » PAGE 8

TVK wants postal votes counting to be recorded

CHENNAI
Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam joint general secretary C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar on Wednesday met Chief Electoral Offices Archana Patnaik demanding that the counting of postal ballots for the Tamil Nadu election be video recorded and shared with political parties. » PAGE 8

METROPLUS » 4 PAGES

What exit polls say

The tables show select pollsters' seat-wise predictions in four States and one Union Territory



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

WEST BENGAL				
Pollster	TMC+	BJP	Others	
Matrize	125-140	146-161	6-10	
PMARQ	118-138	150-175	2-6	
People's Pulse	177-187	95-110	1-4	
Total seats: 294				
TAMIL NADU				
Pollster	DMK+	AJADMK+	TVK	
Matrize	122-132	87-100	10-12	
PMARQ	125-145	65-85	16-26	
People's Pulse	125-145	65-80	18-24	
Axis My India	92-110	22-32	98-120	
Total seats: 234				
KERALA				
Pollster	LDF	UDF	NDA	
Matrize	60-65	70-75	3-5	
PMARQ	62-69	71-79	1-4	
People's Pulse	55-65	75-85	0-3	
Axis My India	49-62	78-90	0-3	
Total seats: 140				
ASSAM				
Pollster	BJP+	INC+	Others	
Matrize	85-95	25-32	6-12	
PMARQ	82-94	30-40	1-5	
Axis My India	88-100	24-36	0-3	
Total number of seats: 126				
PUDUCHERRY				
Pollster	AINRC+	INC+	TVK	
Axis My India	16-20	6-8	2-4	
People's Pulse	16-19	10-12	-	
JVC	15-17	11-13	1-2	
Total seats: 30				

Heavy polling in Bengal Phase 2

92.6% turnout recorded as 142 constituencies vote in last phase
Mamata accuses BJP of trying to 'rig' poll at her Bhabanipur seat
EC to retain 700 companies of Central forces in the State

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

There was a record turnout of 92.6% in the second and final phase of polling for the West Bengal Assembly election on Wednesday, amidst isolated incidents of unrest and violence. This is in tune with the record turnout in the first phase, where 93.19% of the electorate cast their votes in 152 seats on April 23.

The total turnout across the two phases stands at 92.9%, the highest polling in any West Bengal Assembly election since Independence, according to the State's Chief Electoral Officer.

In the second phase, polling was held in 142 Assembly seats spread across seven districts. The highest polling rates were recorded in the rural-dominated areas of Purba Bardhaman

Strong mandate

Map shows constituency-wise turnout % (EC data as of 12.30 a.m. on Thursday)



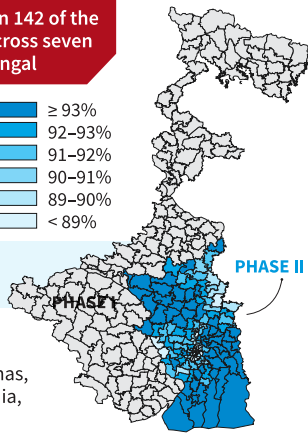
PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Votes were polled in 142 of the 294 seats spread across seven districts of West Bengal

Around 93% of voters in West Bengal exercised their franchise across the two phases after a 12.6% reduction in electorate due to the SIR

PHASE II VOTER TURNOUT 92.6%

The highest turnout among districts was recorded in Purba Bardhaman (93.8%) followed by South 24 Parganas, North 24 Parganas, Howrah, and Nadia, all with more than 92%



(93.83%), followed by South 24 Parganas (93.48%), North 24 Parganas (92.92 %), Howrah (92.59), and Nadia (92.14%), districts.

The lowest turnout was in the Kolkata South administrative district, where 87.84% of voters exercised their franchise. The adjoining Kolkata North administrative district recorded an 89.36% turnout, while the

Hooghly (91.98%) saw a turnout of 92.35%. The polling rate is expected to rise as the final figures are yet to be released by the Election Commission at the time of publication.

The Election Commission has decided to retain 700 companies of the Central forces in the State even after the polling concluded on Wednesday evening.

The Bhabanipur consti-

tuency, which has been the epicentre of the electoral contest with Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee defending the seat against Bharatiya Janata Party leader Suvendu Adhikari, witnessed dramatic moments when Ms. Banerjee started visiting polling booths, accusing Central forces and observers of working on the instruc-

tions of the BJP. "People are supposed to cast their votes, not the police... Can voting take place like this?" Ms. Banerjee asked, alleging that there were attempts to rig the elections at the behest of the BJP. Tensions escalated when Mr. Adhikari arrived in the constituency. The BJP candidate was surrounded by Trinamool supporters, who raised "Joy Bangla" slogans. The commotion continued for several minutes as the BJP candidate, surrounded by a posse of security personnel, went from one booth to another. At one point, Mr. Adhikari was seen running on the streets of Bhabanipur. A similar situation erupted when the BJP leader visited the Kolkata Port Assembly seat as well.

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MANY FIRSTS
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NSO survey shows better health-seeking behaviour, relatively low medical charges

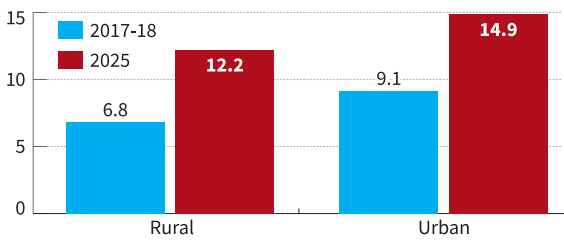
Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

Health-seeking behaviour in India is improving as the proportion of the population reported ailing (PPRA) in 2025 nearly doubled from 2017-18 figures, with rural area numbers going up to 12.2% from 6.8% and those of urban areas rising to 14.9% from 9.1%, according to the latest findings of the National Statistical Office (NSO) in the 80th round of the household consumption health survey released on Wednesday.

Expansion in coverage under government health insurance and financing schemes rose more than threefold – increasing to 45.5% from 12.9% in rural areas, and 31.8% from 8.9% in urban areas, the NSO reported.

Health report

The proportion of urban and rural populations reported to be ailing in 2017-18 to 2025



SOURCE: NATIONAL STATISTICAL OFFICE

Institutional deliveries have risen to 95.6% in rural areas, and to 97.8% in urban areas, the survey said. Covering both rural and urban areas across the country, the survey canvassed 1,39,732 households, including 76,296 households in rural areas and 63,436 households in urban areas.

The findings of the NSO noted that median out-of-

pocket medical expenditure (OOPE) per case of hospitalisation in 2025 has been recorded as ₹11,285, indicating that relatively low expenditure was incurred in over half of the cases of hospitalisation in the country.

Only a small number of high-cost cases were observed to push up the average (mean value), the NSO said.

"This shows that high expenditure is not widespread but limited to specific cases requiring specialised treatment. Moreover, the OOPE in more than half of the entire hospitalisation cases in the public health facilities incur only ₹1,100. Importantly, for non-hospitalisation (outpatient) care, the median OOPE in public health facilities is zero, reflecting that a large proportion of citizens are able to access essential healthcare services entirely free of cost," the survey said.

India has also registered a decline in infectious diseases and a rising prevalence of non-communicable diseases, including diabetes and cardiovascular conditions.

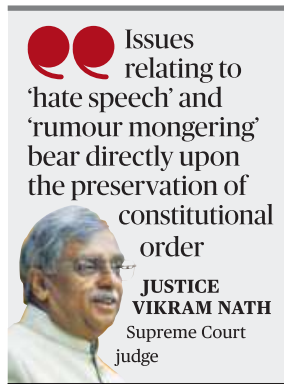
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Hate speech stems from an 'us versus them' mindset: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said that hate speech and rumour-mongering stemmed from an "us versus them" mindset and worked to corrupt a sense of fraternity in a diverse society. However, the court declined to direct the enactment of specific laws against hate speech and crimes, instead calling for effective enforcement of existing laws that cover the offence.

"Hate speech, at its core, stems from a perception of difference that breeds exclusion, where the 'other' is viewed as alien, inferior, or underserving of equal regard," a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta observed in a 125-page



judgment in a series of petitions seeking separate laws for hate speech and crimes. The petitions had also highlighted the unabated presence of hate speech in society despite repeated Supreme Court judgments.

Justice Nath cautioned that as long as the binary of "us" and "them" persisted, the promise of fraternity

would remain unrealised, and true constitutional belonging would prove elusive.

"While we decline to issue directions of the nature sought, we deem it appropriate to observe that issues relating to 'hate speech' and 'rumour mongering' bear directly upon the preservation of fraternity, dignity and constitutional order," Justice Nath said.

The judgment said the court cannot enter into the exclusive legislative domain and craft laws against hate speech and the court left it to the Union government and legislative authorities to consider bringing any specific laws to address the bane of hate speech.

CONTINUED ON
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HC orders probe by CBI into ₹397-cr. transformer purchase

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Wednesday ordered a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the alleged irregularities in the ₹397-crore transformer procurement during V. Senthilbalaji's tenure as Electricity Minister between 2021 and 2023.

The order was passed on the suspicion that the Tamil Nadu government had attempted to suppress the truth and shield high-ranking officials and political figures.

First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Ar-



Irregularities were alleged in transformer procurement during Senthilbalaji's tenure as Electricity Minister.

vind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan said anti-corruption organisation Arappor Iyakkam had lodged a complaint against Mr. Senthilbalaji, Tangedco former chair-

man Rajesh Lakhoni, and Tangedco Financial Controller (Purchase) V. Kasi as early as on July 6, 2023.

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC), in turn, wrote to the State government on January 22, 2024, seeking permission to conduct a 'detailed inquiry'.

Since there was no progress thereafter, Arappor Iyakkam filed the present petition in the High Court in March 2024, seeking a direction to the DVAC to register an FIR based on its complaint.

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Iran better 'get smart soon' over nuclear plans: Trump

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

U.S. President Donald Trump warned Tehran on Wednesday that it should "get smart soon" and capitulate demands for tight controls on its nuclear programme, as a U.S. naval blockade turned the screws on Iran's economy. Meanwhile, U.S. press reports suggested Mr. Trump has decided to reject Iran's proposed deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 16

657 trafficked cultural artefacts returned to India in \$14 million restitution, says U.S.

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

U.S. authorities have announced the return of 657 antiquities, collectively valued at nearly \$14 million, to India. The pieces were recovered pursuant to several ongoing investigations into criminal trafficking networks, including those of alleged antiquities trafficker Subash Kapoor and convicted trafficker Nancy Wiener.

The artefacts were returned at a ceremony attended by the Consul-General of India, Rajlakshmi Kadam, in New York.

"The scale of the traf-



A red sandstone Buddha figure worth \$7.5 million, which has been returned to India.

ficking networks that targeted cultural heritage in India is massive, as demonstrated by the return of more than 600 pieces to-

day," Manhattan District Attorney Alvin Bragg said in a statement.

Sources said the 657 antiquities were delivered in three phases: 612 were returned in November 2024, 26 in July 2025, and in the third phase, 19 were returned to India on Tuesday. Of the 19, 17 are linked to Kapoor.

Among the pieces being returned is a red sandstone figure of Buddha standing with his right hand raised in *abhaya mudra*, a gesture of protection. The Buddha's feet are broken below the knees, and only fragments of the halo behind his head remain – damage

that likely occurred when the statue was looted from northern India. The statue worth \$7.5 million was smuggled into New York by Kapoor and later seized by the Antiquities Trafficking Unit from one of his storage units.

Another returned artefact is a bronze figure of Avalokiteshvara, seated on an inscribed double-lotus base over a lion-flanked throne. The inscription identifies the craftsman as Dronaditya of Sirpur, located near modern-day Raipur in Chhattisgarh.

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Govt. hospitals across T.N. open special units for heat stroke cases

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

All government medical college hospitals across the State have been instructed to ensure comprehensive preparedness measures for prevention and management of heatwave-related illnesses, including operationalising heat stroke management units, maintaining adequate stocks of oral rehydration salts (ORS) and essential medicines, training healthcare personnel, drawing up emergency response plan, carrying out fire safety audits and awareness for the public.

In a circular dated April 28, Director of Medical Education (DME) and Research R. Suganthi Rajakumari asked all deans/heads of institutions to take steps to maintain adequate stocks of intravenous fluids, ice packs, and other supplies required for effective cooling and management of heat-related illnesses. Capacity building of healthcare personnel and community health workers should be ensured for early identification, prompt management, and proper reporting of such cases. Adequate arrangements for treatment of heat stroke patients round-the-clock should be made.

Hospitals should also take up fire safety audits and adopt heat-resilient practices, including cool-roof technologies and provision of adequate shading within healthcare facilities. These should be prioritised to safeguard patients and healthcare workers during extreme heat events. They should also step up public awareness on prevention of heat-related illnesses, particularly sensitising vulnerable populations and educating the public on appropriate precautions during peak heat hours.

For ambulance and primary care preparedness, the directorate asked institutions to identify resources at health facilities and for ambulances to ensure on-site emergency and rapid cooling of patients with severe heat-related illness in line with “Cool First, Transport Second” strategy.

Health facilities should conduct regular fire risk assessments and inspections to identify vulnerable areas and to ensure functional fire fighting systems. As a part of fire prevention measures, proper storage and handling



Hospitals have been asked to maintain adequate stocks of medical supplies to manage heat-related illnesses. R. RAGU

of flammable materials should be ensured, while bi-annual electrical load audits, especially in high-demand areas like ICUs, should be conducted to ensure power systems meet safety standards.

The directorate stressed on continuous training for staff on fire safety protocols, prevention and evacuation procedures. Hospitals should establish and maintain an emergency response plan with Standard Operating Procedures for evacuating patients and staff and ensure all staff members are familiar with emergency roles and responsibilities. Adopt measures to reduce indoor heat and energy conservation in the health facilities like cool roof /green roof, window shading, rainwater harvesting and solarisation.

At the Government Kilpauk Medical College (KMC) Hospital, a dedicated heat stroke ward has been set up, while temperature monitoring devices, rapid cooling methods for treatment of heat stroke and ice cold saline and dialysates are available for treatment.

Oral rehydration counters have been set up in different places of KMC. Heat-related illness management programme was conducted for doctors and paramedical staff, while posters on heat-related illness, clinical protocols have been displayed for easy reference.

Information Education and Communication materials on heat-related illness were displayed in different places of the hospital for patient awareness.

At the Rajiv Gandhi Government General Hospital, authorities said that there was adequate number of intensive care unit beds, and the casualty too was prepared to treat patients with any heat-related symptoms.

Rising temperatures hit vegetable supply, inflate prices in city

On Wednesday, the Koyambedu market received only 300 truckloads of vegetables compared to the usual 400, as arrivals from A.P. , Karnataka dipped

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Rising mercury levels across Tamil Nadu and neighbouring States have taken a toll on vegetable availability, tightening supply and pushing up prices. While northern Tamil Nadu may continue to sizzle, heavy rainfall may bring respite to some southern districts till weekend.

Prolonged dry weather in key produce zones of Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, major suppliers for Koyambedu wholesale market – one of the Asia’s largest perishable goods hubs – has hit vegetable arrivals.

Tomato prices, a kitchen staple, have climbed to ₹40 a kg in the wholesale market, up from ₹25/kg sold in March. In retail, prices of tomatoes range between ₹50 and ₹55 per kg.

G.D. Rajasekaran, president, Federation of Koyambedu Wholesale Market Merchants’ Associations, said the market received only 300 truckloads of vegetables on Wednesday, compared to the usual 400. Heat damage to crops has led to a 30% shortage in supplies to Chennai.

“If dry weather continues in the neighbouring States and Tamil Nadu, prices may further escalate by 10% in May,” he said.

Chennai gets its major share of tomatoes from the



Weather woes: Prices may further rise by 10% in May if dry weather continues in Tamil Nadu and the neighbouring States. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Palamaner-Madanapalle belt in Andhra Pradesh and Kolar-Srinivasapuram region in Karnataka.

Several other vegetables such as beans (₹90-₹100/kg), carrot (₹50 a kg) and beetroot (₹40/kg) are priced high at the wholesale market. However, onions and potatoes that have a longer shelf life are relatively cheaper.

P. Sukumar, treasurer, Koyambedu Vegetables, Fruits, and Flowers Merchants’ Association, said the cost of lemons and ginger had also increased owing to higher demand.

While such spikes in summer are typical, intense heat in supplying States this year has increased shortage and prices. Even a spell of rain could improve arrivals.

Meanwhile, the Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC) has forecast isolated heavy rainfall in parts of south Tamil Nadu and the Western Ghats districts till May 2. Some interior districts may also experience

showers through the weekend. V.R. Durai, Director, Regional Weather Forecasting Centre, RMC, said the prevailing trough, which is shifting inland along with weather systems in neighbouring States, would influence convective thunderstorm activity in Tamil Nadu.

Chennai’s Nungambakkam and Meenambakkam recorded 35.7 degrees Celsius and 39.3 degrees Celsius respectively.

The RMC has warned coastal areas of hot and humid conditions due to moisture-laden winds and high temperatures. The maximum temperature in Chennai will hover around 38 degrees Celsius on Thursday.

On Thursday, the Nilgiris, Coimbatore, Erode, Salem and Dharmapuri may receive isolated heavy rainfall. However, north Tamil Nadu and coastal places such as Chennai may have to wait longer for seasonal thunderstorms, he said.



Dinesh Balaji J.D., consultant paediatric surgeon and paediatric urologist, Rainbow Children’s Hospital, addressing the media on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

10-year-old boy ailing from massive germ cell tumour treated at private hospital

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 10-year-old boy with a germ cell tumour, was treated at the Rainbow Children’s Hospital in Chennai recently.

Addressing a press meet held on Wednesday, Dinesh Balaji J.D., consultant paediatric surgeon and paediatric urologist at the hospital, explained that the patient had come in with complaints of recurrent respiratory infections.

Imaging and an ultrasound-guided core needle biopsy revealed the presence of a huge tumour in the chest that was malignant. The 13x11 cm tumour occupied nearly half of his chest, completely filling the right side and pushing the heart to one side, while also adhering to major blood vessels, and compromising the child’s ability to breathe.

Dr. Balaji said that this was a mediastinal germ cell tumour. After five cycles of chemotherapy, there was a gradual reduction in the tumour size. However, surgical management was required.

A sternotomy was decided on for vascular control and tumour access. The tumour was completely excised with the surgery, the child was placed on ventilator support for a day, and discharged after four days. Imaging after the surgery showed that there was no sign of the cancer, he said.

Nandhini G., senior consultant, paediatric surgeon and paediatric urologist, stressed the need for a multidisciplinary approach in such cases, where several specialists together decide on the right approach. The doctors also emphasised the need for parents to listen to their children and not ignore early symptoms.



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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

SHRI L. Swaminathan, aged 101, peacefully attained the feet of his beloved Rama at No.4/1, Sunrise Avenue, Neelankarai, Chennai 600115 on April 28. Rita Mohan and P. N. Mohan.



C MOHANARAGAM
Proprietor: Vasanthi Enterprises
DOB:30.04.1965 DOD:28.04.2026
Deeply missed by
Mother: Vasanthi
Wife: Yasodha, Son: Harshanth
Brother and Sister Family

WITH PROFOUND grief we announce the death of our mother, G.S. NIRMALA wife of G.Sudarsan in Chennai on 29 April 2026. Mourned by family and friends

In Loving Memory



Mrs. Angelina George
DOB: 14.04.1933 Homecall: 28.04.2026
"Entered into God's Glory"
The funeral service will be held at
St Luke's Church, Mandaveli
on Thursday, the 30th April 2026
at 1.30 PM
followed by the burial at
Kilpauk Cemetery.

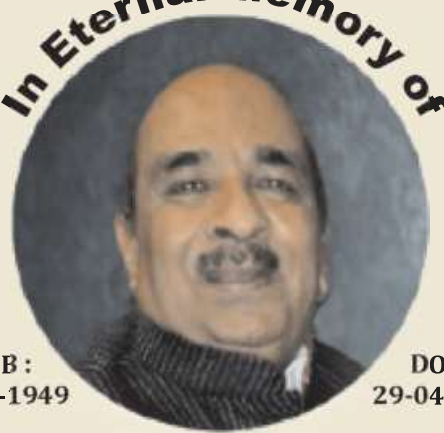
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DEATH

Jai Bikhu, Jai Mahashraman



In Eternal Memory of

DOB : 25-11-1949 DOD : 29-04-2026

Sri S. Pannalal Tatia
With profound grief, we announce the passing of Sri S. Pannalal Tatia, a beloved husband, father, grandfather, and the revered patriarch of the family.

Mahaprayan yatra will begin from the residence at 10.30 am and proceed to Kannamapettai, T.Nagar

Deeply mourned by
Wife : Chandrakanta Tatia
Son & Daughter in law: Bharat & Sangita Tatia
Grand son & Grand daughter in law: Jaijash & Riddhi Tatia
Daughters & Sons-in-law: Antriksh Kumbhat, Shoba & Akkshay Nahar, Chandana & Madhur Khandelwal
Grandchildren: Nirpeksh & Diksha Kumbhat, Henna & George John, Rijuta & Yash Nathvani, Aditi & Anmol Nahar, Arya Khandelwal
Great Grand Child: Neil George
Nephews & Family: Deepak & Jaya Tatia, Praveen & Pooja Tatia, Tanvi & Rithvi Tatia, Aadish Tatia
Sasural Paksh: Madanchand , Narendra, Rajesh, Ashok Ranjeet, Sandeep, Deepak & Vishal Bohra

Homage meeting on 1st May at 4 PM at Hotel Taj Coromandel, Nungambakkam

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CENTENARY COMMEMORATION
1926 – 2026



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30-4-1926 to 30-4-2026

FOUNDERS' DAY – CENTENARY CELEBRATION
DATE: 30th April 2026 | TIME: 6:00 p.m.
VENUE: Trinity Acute Care Hospital, No-33, Desika Road, Alwarpet, Mylapore, Chennai – 600 004
* ALL ARE WELCOME *
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Youth who fled Karur after murder held in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 19-year-old youth, who escaped after murdering a 79-year-old woman and stealing her gold jewellery in Karur district on April 26, was nabbed by the Government Railway Police at the Central Railway Station on Wednesday.

Thayaramal was found dead with her hands and legs tied at her residence in Karuppur Salapatti in Karur on April 26.

Gold jewellery weighing about six grams, including earrings and a nose ring, was reported missing.

☀️🌧️	Timings	
CHENNAI		
THURSDAY, APR. 30		
☀️ RISE	05:49	🌃 SET 18:24
🌧️ RISE	17:21	🌃 SET 04:34
FRIDAY, MAY. 01		
☀️ RISE	05:49	🌃 SET 18:24
🌧️ RISE	18:10	🌃 SET 05:12
SATURDAY, MAY. 02		
☀️ RISE	05:48	🌃 SET 18:24
🌧️ RISE	19:01	🌃 SET 05:53

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	40	26
Chennai Airport	39	29
Chennai City	36	29

Chennai Airport Today
39°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be hot and uneasy. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C The weather will be dry. Day will be slightly hot and uneasy. Night will be comfortable.

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Draft MoU sent to Railway Board for final nod in CMRL's takeover of MRTS

On approval, the State government will sign the MoU with Southern Railway; the takeover process will go on for two years; the govt. has also been in talks with multilateral banks to seek funding for implementing the project, according to sources

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

After numerous rounds of deliberations that went on for months, Southern Railway has forwarded the draft Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for the takeover of MRTS by Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) to the Railway Board for approval.

If this comes through, the State government will sign the MoU with Southern Railway to commence the takeover process.

In July last year, after a long wait, the Railway Board cleared this project, which allows the CMRL to



Long delay: Initially, the signing of the MoU was expected to be held in December last year. It was then postponed to March and now to June. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

eventually gain control of the MRTS network. This will give a much-needed impetus to the MRTS network, as it will be modernised on par with CMRL.

The Tamil Nadu government has also been in talks

with multilateral banks to seek funding to implement this project, sources said.

“The draft document was sent to the Board recently. Along with that, some more recommendations from the Tamil Nadu

The draft MoU comprises various aspects such as operations and asset management

government have been forwarded by the Southern Railway to the Board,” a source said.

The draft MoU comprises various aspects, including operations and asset management, such as cost sharing with respect to land and assets such as rolling stock or train.

This aside, the takeover process will go on for two years and hence, details are worked out to how to facilitate this, another source said.

The MRTS network,

which was launched decades ago, connected Chennai Beach with Velachery, but recently, the extension from Velachery to St. Thomas Mount too, became operational.

While commuters were excited when the approval was given for the CMRL's takeover of the MRTS project last year, the process was gradual.

Initially, the signing of the MoU was expected to be held in December last year. It was then postponed to March, and now to June.

The CMRL too, is awaiting the signing of this MoU, so that they can call for bids to procure trains and bring a consultant on board to plan the station upgrade.

2 booked for duping woman of ₹4.8 lakh by promising job

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have registered a case against two men, including a local Congress functionary, for allegedly duping a woman of ₹4.8 lakh, promising to get her a government job.

Police sources said the complainant, Ramani, 41, of MKB Nagar, had quit her job as a teacher in April 2024. She then began looking for a government job.

During this period, she was approached by Amir Hamsa, the Congress functionary, who promised to get a job for her through an associate, identified as Sasikumar, in exchange for ₹6 lakh.

The police said Ramani paid the amount in instalments. Subsequently, Amir Hamsa sent her an appointment order online.

However, upon verifica-

Amir Hamsa, a Cong. functionary, promised to get a job for Ramani, through an associate, Sasikumar, in exchange for ₹6 lakh

tion, the document was found to be forged. When confronted, the accused returned ₹1.20 lakh, but failed to repay the remaining ₹4.80 lakh, the police said.

Complaint filed
Following this, Ramani filed a complaint with the MKB Nagar crime wing police.

Based on her complaint, a case was registered against Amir Hamsa and Sasikumar, both residents of Washermanpet, on charges of cheating and forgery.

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IDBI Bank Ltd. invites sealed tenders from reputed Advertising, PR and Social Media handling Agencies for executing communication functions. Please visit the Bank's website www.idbi.bank.in for Request For Proposal (RFP) document and format for submitting the application. Interested bidders are requested to submit the bids as directed therein.

Any amendments/ modifications/ changes including any addendum in the RFP shall be notified only on the Bank's Website.

Date: 30/04/2026
Place: Mumbai

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Chief General Manager

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Panel Members

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Science & Humanities,
Management, SRM Institute of
Science & Technology

Geetha Ramamoorthi
Global GCC Leader,
Former MD, KBR Inc.

Roch Ferreira
Global Vice President & Head of
Corporate Marketing,
Virtusa Corporation

M Soundariya Preetha
Deputy Chief of Bureau,
The Hindu (Moderator)

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National Highways Authority of India
(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways)

भर्ती सूचना/RECRUITMENT NOTICE

भारतीय राष्ट्रीय राजमार्ग प्राधिकरण (भा.रा.रा.प्रा.) संविदा आधार पर निम्नलिखित पदों के लिए भर्ती हेतु आवेदन आमंत्रित करता है:-
National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) invites applications for recruitment to the following posts **on contract basis**:-

Name of the posts	No. of posts*
प्रतिष्ठित बाह्य पेशेवर (परिवहन योजनाकार) Eminent External Professional (Transport Planner)	01
प्रतिष्ठित बाह्य पेशेवर (परिवहन अर्थशास्त्री) Eminent External Professional (Transport Economist)	01

*पदों की संख्या भा.रा.रा.प्रा. की आवश्यकता के अनुसार बढ़ाई या घटाई जा सकती है।
*Number of posts may increase / decrease as per requirement of NHAI.
2. पात्रता मानदंड और अन्य शर्तें भा.रा.रा.प्रा. की वेबसाइट **www.nhai.gov.in** पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
Eligibility criteria and other conditions may be seen on NHAI's website **www.nhai.gov.in**
3. आवेदन जमा करना: इच्छुक और पात्र उम्मीदवार अपने आवेदन **29.05.2026 (सारांश 06:00 बजे तक)** भा.रा.रा.प्रा. की वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध लिंक के माध्यम से केवल ऑनलाइन जमा करें।
Submission of Applications: Applications are to be submitted online only. Eligible candidates may apply online on the link provided on the website of NHAI by **29.05.2026 (upto 06:00 PM)**.
4. इस विज्ञापन के संबंध में शुद्धिपत्र / अनुरोध / निरस्तीकरण, यदि कोई होगा तो, उसे केवल भा.रा.रा.प्रा. की वेबसाइट पर प्रकाशित किया जाएगा।
Corrigendum/Addendum/Cancellation to this advertisement, if any, shall be published on NHAI website only.

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CENTRAL RAILWAY

REPLACEMENT WORK

Open E-Tender Notice No. KYN-LD-585-W-765-Cont dtd. 28.04.2026. Sr.DEE(TD), KYN. Name of Work : Replacement of corroded steel structures in Diwa-Kalyan-Igatpuri (NE) section of Mumbai Division for improving safety and reliability. Approx Value: ₹86674033.65, EMD: ₹1733500.00. Cost of Tender Form: 0.00. Completion period: 24 months. The time and date for submission of tender will be up to 11.00 Hrs. on 28.05.2026. Complete details of E-tender are available at official Railway website **http://www.ireps.gov.in** the complete documents can be downloaded from the website. The detail of tender is available in the "Notice Board" of the Sr. DEE(TD) KYN's office, Kalyan.

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THE HINDU

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अडयार, चेन्नै, तमिलनाडु, भारत
Adyar, Chennai - 600 020, Tamil Nadu, India

सीएलआरआई अधिसूचना सं.02/2026
CLRI Notification No.02/2026

साक्षात्कार Interview

सीएसआईआर-सीएलआरआई में अस्थायी आधार पर काम करने के लिए **अंशकालिक चिकित्सक (01 स्थान)** के स्थान पर नियुक्ति हेतु **साक्षात्कार 22 मई 2026** को सीएसआईआर-सीएलआरआई, सरदार पटेल रोड, अडयार, चेन्नै - 600020 में आयोजित किया जाएगा।
Interview for engagement to the position of Part-Time Doctor (01 position) on temporary basis, is scheduled to be held on 22nd May 2026 at CSIR-CLRI, Sardar Patel Road, Adyar, Chennai - 600020.
अर्हताएं, चयन की विधि, लिखित परीक्षा / साक्षात्कार की सारणी और आवेदन प्रपत्र आदि संबंधी पूरी जानकारी के लिए कृपया **https://clri.org** देखें।
For complete details regarding qualification(s), mode of selection, schedule of Written Test / Interviews and proforma for application etc., please visit : **https://clri.org**
Sd/-
वरिष्ठ प्रशासन नियंत्रक
Senior Controller of Administration



KARNATAKA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

(CIN: U40109KA1999SGC025521)
No. CEE/T&P/SE-2/2026-27/873-85 Date:29.04.2026

BRIEF SHORT-TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPPP mode only)

KPTCL invites Bids on electronic mode for the following works against following enquiry numbers on Partial Turnkey Basis:

Enquiry No's. and Name of the works

(1) KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT3679
Establishing 1x20 MVA,110/33kV & 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Anthapura village** with Construction of associated line for a distance of **14.98 Kms** in Sandur Taluk, Ballari District and 2 no's. Terminal Bays at 110/11kV KIADB Kuduthini sub-station in Ballari Taluk, Ballari District.

(2) KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT3680
Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Sandur town (Doulathpura)** with associated line for a distance of **0.416km** in Sandur Taluk, Ballari District.

(3) KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT3681
Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Bandri Village** along with associated lines and terminal bays in Sandur Taluk, Ballari District.

The bids will be received through electronic tendering mode only. The details regarding participation in the e-tendering process can be obtained by logging on to KPTCL website **https://kptcl.karnataka.gov.in** with hyperlink **"E Procurement KPTCL"** or **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in on or after 06.05.2026 at 15:00 hrs.** Last date & time for receipt of Bids and any extension of Due date for Bid submission will be intimated in the Karnataka Public Procurement portal. Any details required in this regard can also be obtained from the office of the undersigned during office hours.
All Corrigendum/Addendums shall be noticed by the bidders before the last date of submission of the Bids.
Sd/- **Chief Engineer, (Electy) Tendering & Procurement, KPTCL, 9th Floor, Indhana Bhavan, A.R. Circle, Bengaluru-560009.**



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Civil Aviation Department
Patna Airport, Patna –14.
TEL. No:- 0612-2225659, 2224423, e-mail-cadbihar@bihar.gov.in
Letter. No: सिविलिन् (संभारण) 16–10/2023- 560
CORRIGENDUM
PR.NO.-027410 (Civil Aviation) 2025-26 & PR.NO.-001384 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27
CHANGE IN SCHEDULE OF TENDER
With reference to our Tender Ref. No.- सिविलिन् (संभारण) 16–10/2023–420 Dt. 30.03.2026 and Corrigendum no.-520 dated-17.04.2026 for Purchase of Spares and Consumables (as per annex.-I) for King Air C-90 A/B VT-EBG Aircraft, we hereby revise the **Tender schedule** as below:-

Sl.No	Activity	Date & Time
1	Physical Bid Submission (both Technical & Financial Bid) Last Date	Up to 14.05.2026 at 05:00 PM
2	Technical Bid & Financial Bid Opening Date (Tentative)	15.05.2026 at 3:00 PM
3	Tender Bid Validity	120 Days

Note:- Tenders submitted on or before the due date of 30.04.2026 will be considered valid and included in the evaluation process.
If required interested and qualified agencies may send their queries throughmail cadbihar@bihar.gov.in
For detailed notification or further updates, kindly visit the **https://state.bihar.gov.in/cad/**
Other terms and conditions of the tender published in PR.NO.-027410 (Civil Aviation) 2025-26 and PR.NO.-001384 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27 will remain unchanged.
Deputy Secretary
Civil Aviation Department
PR. No. 002101 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27
For further details please visit : **www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar**
अपने जीवन साथी के प्रति वफादार रहें,
किसी अनजान स्त्री/पुरुष से असुरक्षित यौन संबंध से बचें।



CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

Open Global E-Tender

No. COS/CRJ/PUB/e-Tender/19/0162, Date: 25/04/2026. The following e-Tenders can be accessed under the link **www.ireps.gov.in**. Offers for such e-Tender can be submitted only electronically by accessing the link **www.ireps.gov.in → login → E-Tender Stores/Supply**. Vendors may also contact the following officials to obtain clarification regarding particular tender or IREPS related information if any, Dy.CMM/HQ/ CLW/ Chittaranjan, 9163340711 or AMM/HQ, 9163340713. **Office Address:** Office of The PCMM /CLW/Chittaranjan, SL No.:[1]. **Tender No.:**73261020, **Brief Description of Item:** Main Gear Bearing, Intermediate Gear Bearing and Pinion Bearing for Aluminium Gear Case of WAP-5 as per CLW's Drg. No. 1210-01.311-021, 1210-01.411-022, 1210-01.411-023, Each set contains 3 items in 24 Nos. [Warranty Period: 72 Months after the date of delivery]. **Quantity:**79.00 Set. **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 200000.00 (INR)/0.00 (USD). **Tender Closing Date & Time (IST):**26/05/2026 at 11:00 AM. **PR8/336 PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan**
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SOUTHERN RAILWAY
(SIGNAL & TELECOMMUNICATION WORKSHOP)
PODANUR
E-Tender

For and on behalf of the President of India, The Chief Workshop Manager, Signal and Telecommunication Workshop, Podanur, Coimbatore - 641023, invites E-Tender for the following works as per Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) in the portal **www.ireps.gov.in** Tenderers/Contractors intending to apply for the tender needs to get enrolled in the portal **www.ireps.gov.in** and only online tenders will be accepted. The Bid Security deposit should be made through online payment gateway or through available modes as mentioned in Tender document.

TENDER NOTICE No. SGW-S-203-DB-645297-26 dated 27.04.2026

1. Name of work	Deburring and Flash removal of the insulating components of Q-relay in Machine Shop at S&T/Workshop/ Podanur for a period of Two year.
2. Approximate cost of the work	₹ 21,03,264/- Including GST @ 18%
3. Earnest money to be deposited	₹ 42,100/-
4. Completion period of work	24 Months
5. Date and time of closing of tender	15.00 Hrs of 19.05.2026
6. Website particulars	www.ireps.gov.in

For further details, visit office of the Chief Workshop Manager, Signal and Telecommunication Workshop, Podanur, Coimbatore - 641023.
Assistant Works Manager
For Chief Workshop Manager
S&T Workshop, Podanur.



EMPLOYEES' PROVIDENT FUND ORGANISATION
(Ministry of Labour & Employment, Govt. of India)
REGIONAL OFFICE,
P.b.no.588, Sree Complex, 'D' Block, No.18, Madurai Road, Tiruchirappalli
Phone: 0431-2701126, 2700531, Email: ro.trichy@epfindia.gov.in

In connection with determination of EPF and allied dues for the non-remittance period, the EPFO, Regional Office, Trichy, had initiated inquiries under section 7A of the Act against the 6 branches of the establishment **M/s. Pommys Garments (India) Private Limited/ Pommys Apparels/ Pommys Garments (India) Limited**, which are under liquidation. Further, the said inquiries are still ongoing, and the details of such cases are as follows,

Sl.No.	PF Code No.	Period of Default	Summon Dated	Diary No.
1.	CBTRY1647173000	01/2022 to 04/2025	03.12.2025	316/2025
2.	CBTRY1647722000	01/2022 to 05/2025	03.12.2025	315/2025
3.	CBTRY0082551000	01/2022 to 05/2025	03.12.2025	317/2025
4.	CBTRY1647258000	01/2022 to 07/2025	02.12.2025	335/2025
5.	CBTRY1534742000	08/2017 to 07/2025	02.12.2025	332/2025
6.	CBTRY1647142000	01/2022 to 07/2024	28.11.2025	269/2025

Now, therefore, all concerned stakeholders of the said establishment are hereby informed and called upon to appear in the hearing on **05.05.2026 @ 11.30 AM** through virtual mode along with the relevant documents in this regard without fail. For appearing virtual hearing, a request may be sent to this office mail id **ro.trichy@epfindia.gov.in**, so that the link for the said hearing will send to your return mail.
In case of failure to attend the enquiry on the specified date, the matter will be decided **Ex-parte** based on available records. This publication shall be treated as valid and sufficient notice to all concerned stakeholders of the said establishment
ASHISH KUMAR TRIPATHI
REGIONAL P.F. COMMISSIONER-I
EPFO, RO, TRICHY



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS

National Highways Act 1956 (48/1956) Section 3E(1)
PUBLIC NOTICE
Announcement of Award for acquisition of land for construction of National Highway for Land Owners/ Persons interested there in

Kind attention of all land owners/interested persons is invited to the Notification issued under Section 3A of the NH Act, 1956 for acquisition of land and building for formation of National Highway and the Notification issued under Section 3D of the NH Act, 1956 as noted below: Above Notifications are published in the following newspapers : Dinakaran (Tamil) 2. The Hindu (English)

KANCHIPURAM DISTRICT							
SRIPERUMBUDUR TALUK							
Sl. No	Name of Village	3A(1) Gazette Date	3A(3) News Paper Date	3D(1) Gazette Date	3G(3) News Paper Date	Additional - IV Award	Award Date
1	Molachur	04.11.2025	09.11.2025	31.12.2025	06.01.2026	Rc.No.08/2025/NH/U-I	05.02.2026
2	Podavur	04.11.2025	09.11.2025	31.12.2025	06.01.2026	RC.No. 23/2025/NH/U-II	03.02.2026
3	Nanthimedu	04.11.2025	09.11.2025	31.12.2025	06.01.2026	RC.No.22/2025/NH/U-I	05.02.2026
4	Kiloy	04.11.2025	09.11.2025	31.12.2025	06.01.2026	08/2026/CALA/NH/Unit-III	16.02.2026
5	Sirukiloy	04.11.2025	09.11.2025	31.12.2025	06.01.2026	07/2026/CALA/NH/Unit-III	29.01.2026
Sl. No	Name of Village	3A(1) Gazette Date	3A(3) News Paper Date	3D(1) Gazette Date	3G(3) News Paper Date	Supplementary Award (Main) Award No.	Award Date
1	Ayakolathur	13.12.2016	01.04.2017	05.12.2017	01.01.2018	147(3) /2018/BCE/NH	18.11.2025
2	Sriperumbudur	04.03.2016	05.05.2016	03.03.2017	09.04.2017	280(5) /2017/BCE/NH	10.02.2026

It is informed that the undersigned has announced the Award in respect of the said land under Section 3G of the NH Act, 1956 vide order dates as mentioned above. The land acquiring agency (MoRTH/ NHAI/NHIDCL) has placed the requisite amount of compensation at the disposal of the undersigned. Notices have also been issued to the concerned landowners / interested persons as required under Section 3E of the NH Act, 1956.
Accordingly, as per provisions of the section 3E(1) of the National Highways Act 1956, all the concerned landowners/ interested persons are hereby informed/ notified through this additional Public Notice that the claimants entitled to receive the Compensation amount may collect their amount of compensation from the office of the undersigned on any working day between 10.00 AM to 05.45 PM within a period of 60 days and surrender or deliver the possession of the subject land to the undersigned, failing which the possession of subject land will be taken with police assistance on expiry of the period of 60 days. If not, action will be taken as per section 3E(2) (a) (b) of National Highways Act 1956.

Sl.No	Old S.No	New S.No	Classification	Extent in Sq.mtr.	Land Owner Name
District: KANCHEEPURAM Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR Village: MOLACHUR (ADDL.III)					
1	281/2A1A1A1A1 pt	281/2A1A1A1A1A1A	Dry	175	Pappaiya Naidu S/o Joseph Naidu
Total				175	
District: KANCHEEPURAM Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR Village: PODAVUR (ADDL.IV)					
1	57/131 A pt	57/131A2	Dry	134	K.Nalini W/o Kumarasamy
2	57/132 A pt	57/132A2	Dry	37	K.Nalini W/o Kumarasamy
Total				171	
District: KANCHEEPURAM Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR Village: NANTHIMEDU (ADDL.III)					
1	108/1H1	108/1H1	Dry	6	A.K.Rajisha W/o A.P. Krishna Sha
2	108/1I	108/1I	Dry	70	R.Prasath S/o R.Sambaiyya
3	108/1J1	108/1J1	Dry	68	Minor Karthick S/o K.SrinivasaRav
4	108/1K1	108/1K1	Dry	66	N.Srinivasarav S/o N.Nagaiyya
5	108/1L1	108/1L1	Dry	102	R.Balaji S/o Narayannan
6	108/12	108/12	Dry	27	Ramamoorthy S/o Parthasarathi
7	108/15A	108/15A	Dry	31	Arunasalam S/o Kathikeyan
8	108/16A	108/16A	Dry	24	Arunasalam S/o Kathikeyan
9	108/17A	108/17A	Dry	22	Lakshmi W/o Rajenthira Babu
Total				416	

District: KANCHEEPURAM		Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR		Village: KILOY - ADDITIONAL - IV	
1	54/1A Pt	54/1A2	Dry	442	Thiru. Suresh Golecha S/o Udai Raj Golecha
Total				442	
District: KANCHEEPURAM		Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR		Village: SIRUKILOY - ADDITIONAL - IV	
1	1/2A1 Pt	1/2A1A1A2	Wet A	174	Thiru. A. Thanthoni Naicker
2	1/8A1A Pt	1/8A1A1B	Wet A	200	Thiru. Sathiyam S/o Kuppusamy
3	1/9A1A Pt	1/9A1A2	Wet A	89	Thiru. Padam chanth Poongaliya S/o Poonamchanth Poongaliya
Total				463	
District: KANCHEEPURAM		Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR		Village: AYAKOLATHUR SUPPLEMENTARY AWARD (MAIN)	
1	145	145/2	Wet	38	1. Thiru. Bhimalingam 2. Karunakaran 3. Gunasekaran
2	148/5 Pt	148/5B	Wet	2	Thiru. Dinesh Surana
3	149/1	149/1	Wet	32	1. Thiru. S.B. Rafeeqe 2. Thiru. C.P. Sameer 3. Thiru. A. Anzad
4	149/3	149/3	Wet	11	Thiru. Sri Ramulu
5	150/2 Pt	150/2B	Wet	57	1. Thiru. Mohammad Noorullah 2. Mohammad Jaheer Hussain
6	168/1 Pt	168/1B	Wet	36	Thiru. Prakash S/o Narayanasamy
7	170/4B Pt	170/4B2	Wet	9	Thiru. Santhakumar
8	171/3	171/3B	Wet	12	Thiru. Prakash S/o Narayanasamy
9	231/3 Pt	231/3B	Wet	34	G. Rajalakshmi
10	231/4 Pt	231/4B	Wet	31	Thiru. Santhakumar
11	232 Pt	232/2	Wet	18	G. Rajalakshmi
12	236/1 Pt	236/1B	Wet	231	Karpagam & 8 Members
13	249/1A Pt	249/1A1B	Dry	40	Balaji Housing Corporation
14	249/7A1A	249/7A1A	Dry	7	Balaji Housing Corporation
15	250/1A1A Pt	250/1A1A1B	Dry	387	Balaji Housing Corporation
16	250/1A2	250/1A2	Dry	110	Dhanajayan
17	252/1A2A1	252/1A2A1A1A2	Dry	57	Subramanian S/o Venkatachala Iyer
Total				1112	
District: KANCHEEPURAM		Taluk: SRIPERUMBUDUR		Village: SRIPERUMBUDUR SUPPLEMENTARY AWARD (MAIN)	
1	1259/41	1259/41B	Dry	2	Thiru. Rathinavel S/o Kuppu Goundar
2	1261/1C2G	1261/1C2G	Dry	4	Amuna Muhussain D/o Gunaal Banu
3	1261/2A	1261/2A2	Dry	39	Thiru. M.P. Yogananda S/o M. Puttappa
4	1261/2D1A	1261/2D1A1B	Dry	5	1) Thiru. Suresh S/o Chandrasekar, 2) Gayathri W/o Suresh
5	1261/2D1C	1261/2D1C	Dry	2	Tmt. Pitchaiyammal W/o Sakthivel
6	1261/2D1D	1261/2D1D2	Dry	18	Tmt. Pitchaiyammal W/o Sakthivel
7	1261/2D2B	1261/2D2B	Dry	63	Thiru. Narayanan S/o Ramabaradhan
8	1261/3A3	1261/3A3	Dry	39	Munur Hussain D/o Gunaal Banu
9	1264/1A1A	1264/1A1A1B	Dry	421	1) Thiru. Madhavan 2) V. Kanniyappan 3) Ranganathan S/o. Venugopal
10	1267/1A1	1267/1A1	Dry	14	Thiru. Thanthoni S/o Jaganathan.
11	1267/25	1267/25	Dry	44	Thiru. T.V. Sandhanam S/o T.V. Gopalasamy
12	1267/26	1267/26	Dry	138	Thiru. T.V. Sandhanam S/o T.V. Gopalasamy
13	1268/1A1A	1268/1A1A	Dry	11	Tmt. Saroja W/o Chinnasamy
14	1268/1A2	1268/1A2	Dry	4	Thiru. S. Gopikrishnan S/o K. Samiyappan
Total				804	
Competent Authority and Special District Revenue Officer (LA), National Highways, Kancheepuram					

M CH-CE

SOUTHERN RAILWAY

Construction Organization, Ernakulam Jn

TENDER Notice No. 06-CE-CN-ERS-2026-OT Dated 27.04.2026

Name of work	Proposed construction of Road Over bridge in lieu of LC No. 04 Km 10/300-400 at Vallappuzha in Palakkad
Tender Value : ₹ 488.06 Lakhs	Bid Security: ₹ 9.76, 100/-
Completion Period	12 Months
Date and time of tender closing	19/05/2026, 15.00 Hrs

Complete details and tender document will be available at <https://www.irps.gov.in>

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GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

NATIONAL CENTRE FOR DISEASE CONTROL

(DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF HEALTH SERVICES)

22- SHAM NATH MARG, DELHI – 110 054

PUBLIC NOTICE

Applications are invited for engagement of the one post of Senior Consultant (Environmental Health) and one post of Senior Consultant (Capacity Building), for a period of one year at NCDC, Delhi on contract basis through screening cum Selection Mode at NCDC, 22-Sham Nath Marg (Near Civil Lines Metro Station), Delhi – 110 054, as under:-

Name of the Post	No . of Posts	Place of Posting
Senior Consultant (Environmental Health)	1	Delhi
Senior Consultant (Capacity Building)	1	

The last date of submission of application is 16.05.2026. The application must reach this office on or before 16.05.2026, by speed post/ by hand on all working days from 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM at General Services Section Room No.202, NCDC, 22- Sham Nath Marg, Delhi – 110054. Application received after 16.05.2026 will not be entertained.

After Scrutiny of the application forms, only eligible candidates as per ToR will be informed through email to appear for interview with date and time.

The Educational Qualification, ToR and other conditions may be viewed on the NCDC Website: www.ncdc.mohfw.gov.in.

NOTE: The Competent Authority reserves the right to modify or cancel selection process (in part or Full), if need so arises without issuing any further reasons whatsoever.

Administrative Officer

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From Page One

Madras HC orders probe by CBI into ₹397-crore transformer purchase

Subsequently, two individuals associated with the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), too, filed writ petitions in 2025 for similar relief. After the filing of these cases, the State government granted sanction to the DVAC on September 26, 2025 to conduct a ‘preliminary inquiry’ against Mr. Kasi alone, though the complaints had been lodged against the former Minister and the former chairman of Tangedco too.

“The excessive and unjustified delay in granting permission, coupled with the decision to downgrade the investigation from a ‘detailed enquiry’ [without the registration of an FIR] to a preliminary enquiry and limit its scope solely to Kasi, strongly suggests an attempt by the government and relevant authorities to suppress the truth, and these actions create a reasonable suspicion of a cover-up designed to shield high-ranking officials and political figures, thereby undermining the integrity of a free, independent, and fair investigation,” the Bench observed.

Further, citing a catena of decisions rendered by the Supreme Court that had held that the scope of a preliminary inquiry was only to find out whether a cognisable offence had been made out or not and that a preliminary inquiry was not mandatory in corruption cases, the Division Bench said the DVAC had not only conducted a preliminary inquiry but also closed that inquiry on April 4, 2026.

The Bench said the DVAC appeared to have actually conducted a detailed inquiry in the guise of a preliminary inquiry and submitted a 73-page closure report holding that there was not enough evidence to substantiate the allegations against Mr. Kasi.

“If the DVAC was of the view that the complaint failed to establish a cognizable offence, then conducting an exhaustive investigation involving 44 witnesses and 68 documents was entirely unnecessary and legally unjustifiable. Such extensive action by the DVAC clearly demonstrates that they moved far beyond the limited scope of a preliminary inquiry, and instead, engaged in a full-scale probe before even registering the case,” the Bench wrote.

Authoring the verdict, the Chief Justice said: “It is ostensibly clear that the DVAC utilised the preliminary enquiry as a mere pretext to conduct a full-scale investigation without the legally required registration of an FIR.” He also said the State government had failed to explain why it took 20 long months to grant approval for the DVAC inquiry, and the latter had acted in direct conflict with the principles enunciated by the Supreme Court.

The Division Bench agreed with advocate V. Suresh for Arappor Iyakkam and senior counsel V. Raghavachari representing another petitioner that prolonged inaction by the government on their complaints for about 20 months, without any justification, raise serious concerns regarding the legitimacy of the process and must be given substantial weight in evaluating the cases before the court.

“Further, the lack of any justification for failing to initiate action against the other individuals named in the complaint strongly suggests that the matter was handled improperly. This unexplained omission makes it clear that the procedural integrity of the investigation was compromised, indicating that the complaint was not dealt with in a transparent or lawful manner,” the Bench said.

After ordering a *de novo* investigation by the CBI into the matter and directing the DVAC to handover the papers to the central agency within two weeks, the judges said the State government, Tangedco and the DVAC must cooperate with the investigation, so that it could be completed at the earliest.

Senthilbalaji responds

Responding to the High Court order, Mr. Senthilbalaji told reporters in Coimbatore that all procedures were followed as per rules, and denied any loss during his tenure. He said contracts were awarded to the lowest bidders and, where multiple firms quoted the same price, the total quantity was shared among them based on requirement, as a single firm could not meet the entire demand.

INBRIEF



EC holds training programme on vote counting process

Ahead of the counting of votes polled in the Assembly election, scheduled for May 4, the Election Commission of India (EC) on Wednesday organised a training programme on the counting process for Returning Officers, Assistant Returning Officers, District Programmers, and Assistant Programmers in Chennai. Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik and senior officials addressed the participants during the programme held on the Presidency College campus in Chennai.

HC appoints Hindu couple as Muslim child’s legal guardian

Court takes into account that the couple have been caring for the child right from her birth, and the child is identifying them as her parents

B. Tilak Chandar
MADURAI

Considering the welfare of a Muslim child, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has appointed a Hindu couple as the child’s legal guardian.

The court was hearing a civil miscellaneous appeal filed against an order passed by the Family Court, Madurai. The Family Court had dismissed the petition filed by the appellant for appointment as the legal guardian of the child.

The Hindu couple did not have a child, and decided to adopt one. The biological mother of the child was living nearby, and had known the couple for more than 10 years.

The biological mother had three children. The third child, a girl, was born in 2023. The biological mother had lost her husband. Since she was working as a daily wage, and was struggling to provide basic amenities to her children, she offered her third child for adoption by the couple.

The couple started taking care of the girl child. Steps were taken to legalise the adoption, and a petition was filed before the Family Court. The Family



Question of custody: The court was hearing a civil miscellaneous appeal filed against an order passed by the Family Court in Madurai.

Court held that even a non-Muslim can be appointed as a guardian. However, it dismissed the petition on the grounds that the child was a girl, and the couple were considered to be strangers.

A Division Bench of Justices N. Anand Venkatesh and K.K. Ramakrishnan took into account that the child, right from birth, had been taken care of by the Hindu couple, and was identifying them as her parents.

The Guardians and Wards Act, 1890, is religion-neutral, and it will apply to every person desirous of being appointed as a guardian of a minor, and religion becomes one of the considerations when the court deals with the petition in line with Section 17 of the Act. In the consi-

dered view of the court, the right of the appellant to be appointed as a legal guardian is recognised by the Act.

“While implementing the provisions of the Act, the court is exercising its parens patriae jurisdiction for the welfare of the child. It will be in the interest of the child to appoint the appellant as the legal guardian, since the child recognises the appellant and his wife as parents, and the child has been taken care of by the appellant and his wife right from birth,” the court said.

“The court is satisfied with the credentials of the appellant and his wife. The court is also satisfied that consent has been given by the biological mother wholeheartedly,” the court said.

Forest fire in the Nilgiris contained, says State govt.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The forest fire reported in the Nilgiris district has been “totally contained”, and field teams are constantly patrolling the area to prevent the spread of any further fires, an official release said.

Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar, and officials of the Forest Department and the State Disaster Management Authority were closely monitoring forest fires in the district, it added.

The Nilgiris was experiencing a “very challenging fire season this year” for a variety of reasons. The rapid escalation of a forest fire in the Wenlock Downs Reserve Forest was caused by a combination of climatic conditions that turned dry vegetation into highly flammable fuel and drove the fire’s intensity, the release said.

High temperatures, low humidity, and heavy winds interacted to create such a volatile environment, it said. The terrain also played a major role, with steep slopes and unpredictable winds creating various challenges for the containment of the fire.

The area was inspected by the Secretary of Environment, Forests and Climate Change Department, Principal Chief Conservator of Forests and Head of Forest Force, and Special Secretary of Forests on April 27.

T.N. against inclusion of surplus Cauvery water released in monthly schedule



WRD Secretary J. Jayakanthan and Cauvery Technical Cell chairperson R. Subramanian, among others, represented Tamil Nadu virtually at the Cauvery Water Management Authority meeting.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government on Wednesday rejected Karnataka’s contention that the surplus water released to Tamil Nadu during 2025-26 should be taken into consideration for the monthly schedule. The Tamil Nadu government made its position clear at the 50th meeting of the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) on Wednesday.

While 174.500 tmc was due to be released by Karnataka to Tamil Nadu at Biligundlu between June 1, 2025 and April 27, 2026, the quantum realised in Tamil Nadu, including the surplus water, was 326.945 tmc. Pointing this out, Karnataka requested that the surplus be included in the monthly schedule.

An official release from the Tamil Nadu Water Resources Department (WRD) said the State de-

clined to accept Karnataka’s request, contending that Karnataka cannot account for the surplus water that could not be stored in reservoirs in that State.

Tamil Nadu insisted that the release of 2.5 tmc due monthly to the State as mandatory environmental flows should be ensured at Biligundlu as per the Supreme Court judgment, considering the storage in reservoirs in Karnataka, the release said.

As on April 28, the storage in the Mettur dam was 42.397 tmc, and the discharge was 1,503 cusecs for industrial purposes and mandatory environmental flows, Tamil Nadu informed the CWMA. The meeting, held in New Delhi, was chaired by CWMA chairperson S.K. Haldar. WRD Secretary J. Jayakanthan and Cauvery Technical Cell chairperson R. Subramanian, among others, represented Tamil Nadu virtually at the meeting.

TVK demands videographing of counting of postal votes

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

TVK joint general secretary C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar on Wednesday met Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik at the Secretariat in Chennai, and demanded that the counting of postal ballots be videographed in full and shared with political parties.

Speaking to journalists, Mr. Kumar said the party had urged the Election Commission to step up security arrangements in strong rooms where EVMs are kept, and deploy additional Central Reserve Police Force personnel at counting centres on May 4.

State govt. cannot restrict maternity leave to just 12 weeks for third pregnancy, says Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has disapproved of a Tamil Nadu government decision to restrict maternity leave to just 12 weeks for the third pregnancy of women government servants, who are otherwise entitled to 365 days of leave for the first two pregnancies.

Second Division Bench of Justices R. Suresh Kumar and N. Senthil Kumar said there was “absolutely no justification” for the State government to have issued a Government Order (G.O.) to this effect on March 13, 2026.

“This kind of restriction made by the government by issuing a G.O. under the

executive power vested on it under Article 162 of the Constitution and against the dictums laid down by the honourable Supreme Court as well as this court cannot be approved by this court,” the Bench said.

Authoring the verdict for the Bench, Justice Kumar said: “Suffering would be the same irrespective of it being a first, second or third pregnancy and the pre-delivery as well as post-delivery care must be taken by the mothers. Therefore, no discrimination could be shown by the government in approving the maternity benefits, especially maternity leave for the third pregnancy to the employees.”

The court delivered the



There was “absolutely no justification” for a G.O. issued to this effect, the court said.

verdict while allowing a writ petition filed by a Vilupuram district court staff, Shayee Nisha, who had applied for maternity leave from February 2, 2026 to February 1, 2027. However, the Principal District Judge had, on March

27, 2026, restricted her maternity leave period to just three months, citing the G.O. issued on March 13, 2026.

The Division Bench set aside the district judge’s decision and ordered that the petitioner be granted 365 days of maternity leave. “The import of G.O., in our considered view, shall not control the district judiciary in dealing with these kind of applications from pregnant women for sanction of maternity leave, even for third pregnancy,” the Division Bench said.

Cites SC order

It recalled that the Supreme Court had categorically ruled that women

employees cannot be denied maternity leave even during third confinement. Following the dictum, the High Court, too, had passed multiple orders, directing the government to extend maternity leave for third pregnancy.

In January 2026, another Division Bench, also headed by Justice Kumar, disapproved of the act of the Madras High Court administration in denying maternity leave for the third pregnancy of a woman employee, and directed the Registrar-General to circulate a copy of the court order to all judicial officers across the State. Thereafter, the government had come up with the March 13 G.O.

Kalhatti Ghat Road closed to tourists; traffic curbs announced in the Nilgiris

The Hindu Bureau
UDHAGAMANDALAM

The Nilgiris district administration has announced the closure of the Kalhatti Ghat Road to tourist vehicles with immediate effect.

The move follows a Madras High Court order, seeking to control the flow of traffic into the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve (MTR). The district administration also urged residents to contact the police at 9498101260 and procure entry passes for people owning non-TN-43 (Ooty RTO) registered vehicles to be allowed to use the road.

The Nilgiris district police have also announced traffic diversions that are set to come into force on May 1 to control vehicular movement during peak tourist season. Tourist vehicles proceeding towards



The move follows a Madras High Court order, seeking to control the flow of traffic into the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve. M. SATHYAMOORTHY

Udhagamandalam from Mettupalayam have been directed to take a detour at the Kattery Junction and proceed towards Ooty town via Selas, Kattery Dam, Ketti Palada, Kollimalai, and Lovedale, and then towards Manjanakorai and Fern Hill, before heading into town.

Tourists proceeding towards Gudalur and the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve have been asked to follow

similar detours to Fern Hill, and then to Khandal, and join the Ooty-Gudalur Road at Fingerpost.

Tourist buses and tempo travellers from Coonoor reaching Udhagamandalam have been directed to halt at Aavin Junction in Udhagamandalam. The passengers should then take tourist buses to visit the attractions in the town.

Similarly, tourist buses, vans, and tempo travellers

from Kotagiri bound for Udhagamandalam have been asked to stop at the temporary parking lot set up at the Government Arts College in Udhagamandalam, from where tourists can take buses to visit tourist spots. Tourist buses, vans, and tempo travellers from Gudalur headed to Udhagamandalam have also been directed to stop at HPF Junction, from where tourists should take buses to reach their destinations.

Vehicles proceeding to Mettupalayam from Udhagamandalam have been directed to take the Kotagiri Road. No vehicles will be allowed via Burliar and Coonoor.

Starting from May 1, only goods vehicles carrying milk, petrol, and LPG cylinders will be allowed inside Udhagamandalam town from 8 p.m. to 9 a.m.

One of two tiger cubs taken into captivity in the Nilgiris dies

The Hindu Bureau
UDHAGAMANDALAM

One of the two tiger cubs that were taken into captivity by the Forest Department near Solada village, after they were believed to have been abandoned by their mother, died on Monday.

Officials said that a post-mortem would be performed on the remains of the cub, in accordance with the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) protocols. They added that the other tiger cub would be taken to Arignar Anna Zoological Park in Chennai, where it would be raised in captivity.

In a separate incident, an adult tiger was found dead in an open well at

The other cub would be taken to Arignar Anna Zoological Park in Chennai, where it would be raised in captivity

Barwood Estate in the O’Valley forest range in Gudalur. The tiger is believed to have suffered injuries that proved fatal when it fell into the well while trying to catch a wild boar.

Based on the decomposition of the carcasses of the two animals, it is suspected that the incident may have occurred more than two weeks ago. Samples of the animals’ visceral organs have been collected for further analysis to rule out poisoning.

Why ‘digital vigilantism’ is not the problem

The Delhi High Court recently made some observations about “digital vigilantism”, and that statements can sometimes “transcend mere free expression and act as a catalyst for public shaming”. The context is a defamation suit brought before the Court by an individual who allegedly misbehaved with a lady on a domestic flight. The lady attempted to amplify his conduct by posting her ordeal on social media, which was shared by media houses and an actress, who apparently did not verify the allegations made in the post.

These observations and statements once again highlight the growing use of social media to amplify claims of harassment and misconduct due to a sense of collective helplessness and people’s lack of faith in systems to swiftly and adequately address sexual harassment claims.

Whether it was the role social media played in the #MeToo movement in attempting to bring justice to victims of sexual harassment or videos recording instances of harassment posted on TikTok, the bottom line is that social media is being used to “crowd source” retributive action, wherein exposure offers accountability due to institutional inaction, as per Sara Witmer.

Systemic apathy

Justice systems globally, due to their long-drawn-out processes, deliver justice in a belated fashion. Coupled with the apathy and unwarranted intrusion of police authorities and victim blaming, the process of speaking up against sexual harassment is even more challenging. The redress process often becomes a form of punishment for all parties involved.

Due to the lack of processes, systems and institutions in delivering justice, social media is used by victims to bridge the gap between harassment and redress mechanisms. This leads to problems like allegations being



Prachi Dutta

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amplified without any mechanism to verify them, false allegations circulating because of the anonymity offered by social media, lack of accountability, and the reputational loss of all parties involved. It creates a public spectacle rather than actually addressing the issue.

However, when processes and systems continue to fail victims, the need to strengthen these processes is of the utmost importance so that victims do not have to use social media as a redress vehicle to achieve justice. It is crucial to ensure a balance between helping victims while protecting the reputation of the alleged harassers, so that one does not trample on the other in the quest for justice. It is important to maintain the principles of natural justice and fair trial.

On ‘vigilantism’

Another issue is with the terminology of “digital vigilantism”. The word vigilantism in itself invokes a negative connotation. As per Les Johnston, “vigilantism”, by its definition, involves the premeditation of participants who are private citizens; their engagement with the issue would be voluntary.

It is also a social movement, which uses or threatens the use of force and arises when an established order is under threat from the transgression of institutionalised norms and aims to control crime or other social infractions by offering assurances of security both to the participants and to others.

Social media posts in the face of harassment do not fall squarely within the purview of vigilantism as there is no established order that is under threat and there is also absolutely no assurance of security to participants. In fact, both the victims and the perpetrators can be recipients of doxing.

Simply put, when there is a collective failure of processes, then one turns to social media to amplify harassment – this cannot

be defined as “digital vigilantism”.

Social media redressal

There have been several instances of unwarranted behaviour during air travel. Case in point is the incident that occurred in November 2022, when a man urinated on a woman. The airlines was slow to act upon the complaint and it was only once details were made public that the airlines took action against the individual. The fundamental issue, therefore, is to have adequate processes at all levels so that a timely redress can be carried out. For instance, if airlines had proper systems in the form of strict no-fly lists, one may not have to resort to social media amplification.

To draw a parallel between consumer services, when a consumer has an unpleasant experience, they have the right to take to social media to express their displeasure. The outcome is two-pronged – either the service provider will respond with their defence or apologise for the bad experience. This helps other consumers make informed choices before availing the same service. Moreover, in consumer services there are adequate systems and processes that exist before a person takes to social media to express displeasure. Customer grievance teams are often prompt to act on complaints because of the fear of reputational and financial loss. However, justice systems and processes that help to achieve real, legal justice are significantly different. They are not prompt and often refuse to act on complaints of harassment, leaving victims with no choice but to take to other channels to amplify their grievances.

The issue therefore, is not of freedom of expression versus public shaming but the fact that in the face of abject failure of processes, people are left with no choice but to use social media as a tool to achieve justice. To avoid “digital vigilantism”, a collective strengthening of processes and faith in these processes is crucial.

Tamil Nadu’s growth record

The manufacturing sector continues to be the principal driver of growth

STATE OF PLAY

K.R. Shanmugam

Tamil Nadu, which is the second-largest State economy, has sustained a high-growth trajectory, recording a real Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) growth of 10.83% in 2025-26, following 11.19% in 2024-25. This places the State well above the national average of 7.4% and marks two consecutive years of double-digit growth. This performance highlights the State’s strong policy framework, and structural strengths, positioning it as a leading contributor to India’s growth.

Over the medium term, Tamil Nadu’s growth acceleration has been notable. It recorded an average real growth of 9.07% from 2021-22 to 2025-25, compared to 5.21% from 2016-17 to 2020-21, and 7.18% during the pre-COVID period. This suggests a strong post-pandemic recovery supported by targeted fiscal measures and industrial policy. Nominal GSDP expanded from ₹31.19 lakh crore in 2024-25 to ₹35.29 lakh crore in 2025-26, registering a 13.16% growth, which is the highest among States.

Sustained high growth has important fiscal and welfare implications: it enhances revenue buoyancy, expands fiscal space for social and infrastructure spending, and supports employment and income generation, thereby reinforcing inclusive development.

The secondary sector remains the principal driver of growth, expanding by 15.02% in 2025-26, significantly above the national average of 6.6%. Within this, construction and manufacturing recorded strong growth rates of 15.02% and 14.22% respectively, com-



pared to around 7% nationally for both sectors. Tamil Nadu’s industrial base continues to underpin its growth model. It contributes 13.35% to India’s manufacturing GDP. With over 40,000 factories employing about 25 lakh workers, the State ranks first nationally in factory employment.

The services sector, accounting for 53.54% of the Gross Value Added (GVA), grew at 8.54% in 2025-26, slightly below the national average of 9.1%. However, several sub-sectors showed strong momentum, including transport, storage and communication at 13.35% and financial services at 11.11%, indicating broad-based expansion. The primary sector grew by 5.92%, outperforming the national average of 2.7%, driven by a 8.91% recovery in agriculture.

The drivers of growth

Tamil Nadu’s per capita income (NSDP) has nearly doubled from ₹2,096 lakh in 2020-21 to ₹4.08 lakh in 2025-26, the second highest in the country, next only to Karnataka. In comparison, the all-India average stands at ₹2.196 lakh.

The State’s growth is supported by both supply and demand-side factors. On the supply side, the State benefits from strong infrastructure, including reliable power, extensive road and port connectivity, and established industrial corridors. High human capital, reflected in technical edu-

cation and skill development, supports productivity across sectors. The State is also a leading destination for Foreign Direct Investments (FDI), with inflows rising from \$2,169 million in 2022-23 to \$3,681 million in 2024-25.

On the demand side, a large consumer base, rising incomes, and rapid urbanisation sustain strong household consumption. Investment demand remains robust, driven by private sector activity in manufacturing, automobiles, electronics, and renewable energy, supported by a favourable business environment. Public expenditure on infrastructure, education, health, and social welfare further reinforces demand. Export performance also remains a key growth lever. According to NITI Aayog’s Export Preparedness Index, Tamil Nadu ranks second with a score of 64.41, just behind Maharashtra. Importantly, rising demand has been matched by supply-side capacity, helping contain inflation. Retail inflation declined from 5.2% last year to 2.62% in December 2025.

Moreover, Tamil Nadu’s fiscal policy has played a counter-cyclical and developmental role. While the pandemic necessitated expansionary measures, the State has since initiated fiscal consolidation. The fiscal deficit declined from 4.91% of GSDP in 2020-21 to 3% in 2026-27BE, while the revenue deficit reduced from 3.49% to 1.2%. The debt-GSDP remains around 26%. Overall, the State’s strong growth momentum, rising FDIs, and robust export performance provide a solid foundation for achieving its ambition of becoming a \$1 trillion economy.

K.R. Shanmugam is former Director, Madras School of Economics, and economic consultant to GoTN.

An SIR-marred turnout in West Bengal

In absolute terms, the increase in voter turnout in the eastern State was lowest among recent electoral cycles

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani
Sambavi Parthasarathy
Pon Vasanth B.A.

West Bengal, where the Assembly polls concluded on Wednesday, recorded a voter turnout of close to 92%, the highest in the State’s electoral history according to provisional figures released by the Election Commission (EC). However, as seen recently in Tamil Nadu, the record turnout was not driven by a sharp increase in voter participation, but by the low base effect of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls shrinking the size of the State’s electorate.

The SIR exercise, which happened in a highly controversial manner in West Bengal, brought down the electorate by nearly 11% from 7.66 crore to 6.26 crore. **Table 1** shows the size and the growth of electors and voters who turned out since 2001. The last SIR happened after the 2001 Assembly polls, which resulted in the electorate declining in size by 1% during the 2006 election. Consequently, the 2006 polls saw a jump in voter turnout. The number of people who voted increased by 7.7%.

Similarly, the number of electors fell from 7.34 crore in the 2021 Assembly election to 6.82 crore in the latest polls, a decline of 7%. However, the number of people who voted increased only by 3.6%. This is the lowest increase in voter participation in at least the last 10 Assembly elections. This could indicate that many eligible voters who would have otherwise voted, could not do so because of the SIR deletions.

A constituency-wise analysis shows that 242 of the 294 constituencies saw an increase in the number of people who voted in the latest polls, compared to the 2021 Assembly election. **Map 2** shows that the constituencies which had an increase in the num-

ber of voters in the 2026 polls were concentrated more in the northern and south-western regions with constituencies such as Chanchal, Domkal, Sitalkuchi registering the highest increases in the range of around 29,000.

A cluster of constituencies across the southern delta and parts of the north regions also exhibited declines. Seats such as Samserganj, Metiaburuz, and Howrah Uttar saw a decline of around 33,500, 24,000 and 19,000 voters respectively compared to 2021.

Table 3 shows that the constituencies that saw the highest deletions during the SIR were also the ones that saw the sharpest increase in voter turnout in percentage terms. For instance, seats like Chowrangee and Jorasanko saw about 40% elector deletions in the latest SIR exercise. These constituencies registered a turnout of about 86% in the latest poll. This is an increase of at least 33 percentage points compared to the 2021 Assembly election.

Seats which experienced the lowest deletions such as Katulpur, Bhagabanpur and Sabang registered voter turnout of more than 90% in the latest polls. However, this was only an increase of less than five percentage points when compared to the 2021 Assembly election. In other words, these constituencies were already turning out in large numbers before.

A regionwise analysis of voter turnout shows that the south-western region, which comprises nearly 117 of the State’s 294 constituencies, saw an increase in the number of people who voted in almost all the constituencies (**Table 4**). This was followed by the northern region, where 48 of the 54 constituencies saw an increase in voters compared to 2021. The Greater Kolkata region, comprising several urban areas, had a high proportion of seats where there was an absolute decrease in the total number of voters who turned out in comparison to 2021.

The denominator effect

The data for the charts were sourced from the Election Commission of India



TABLE 1: West Bengal’s electorate and voter participation across Assembly elections

Election year	Total electors (in crore)	Change in electors (in %)	People who voted (in crore)	Change in voters (in %)	Voter Turnout (in %)
2001	4.86	6.7	3.66	-3.1	75.3
2006	4.81	-1.1	3.94	7.7	81.9
2011	5.62	16.9	4.74	20.2	84.3
2016	6.59	17.2	5.47	15.3	83.0
2021	7.34	11.3	6.04	10.4	82.3
2026	6.82	-7	6.26	3.64	91.8

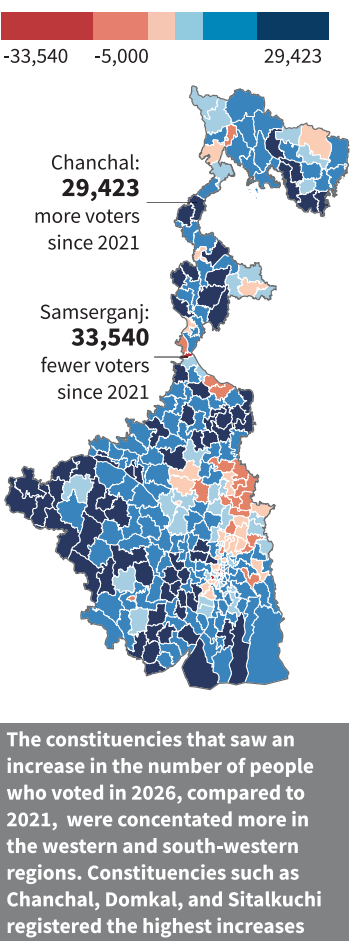
TABLE 3: Voter turnout in constituencies with high deletions during SIR

Assembly Constituency (AC)	Deletions (in %)	Voter turnout in 2021(in %)	Voter turnout in 2026 (in %)	Difference (in %)
Chowrangee	40	53.55	86.5	33
Jorasanko	38	49.99	86.5	36.5
Samserganj	36	80.05	96.0	16.0
HowrahUttar	33	68.51	88.1	19.6
KolkataPort	30	64.61	89.4	24.8
Katulpur	1	90.82	93.3	2.5
Bhagabanpur	2	87.59	92.2	4.6
Sabang	2	89.21	92.6	3.4
Patashpur	2	88.33	92.2	3.9
Mahishadal	2	89.44	89.3	-0.2

TABLE 4: Regional breakdown of constituencies based on whether they saw an increase or decrease in the number of voters between 2021 and 2026

Region	Total number of constituencies	ACs where more people voted in 2026	ACs where fewer people voted in 2026
Greater Kolkata	42	28	14
North	54	48	6
South east	81	55	26
South West	117	111	6

MAP 2 : The constituency-level change in the number of people who voted between 2021 and 2026



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 30, 1976

Navigational survey of entire Indian coast by 1982

Madras, April 29: The Navy’s survey ships, Darshak Jamuna and Sutlej, hoped to complete survey of the entire Indian coast by 1982 to ensure the safety of navigation by home and international shipping in Indian waters, the commanding officer of INS Darshak Commander M.K. Tikku told newsmen here to-day.

Till 1967 only 9,000 square miles of the 148,060 square miles requiring to be surveyed had been made but the pace picked up after the ships equipped themselves with modern electronic gadgets, he said.

INS Darshak the largest and the first modern survey ship of the Navy has come to Madras port after completing surveys in Nicobar and Andaman Islands. The Navy’s hydrographic service has been recognised as one of the finest and best east of the Suez according to Commander Tikku. The three survey ships earn Rs. 5 lakhs in foreign exchange per annum by the sale of their charts to foreign lines. The Indian earnings of each come to around Rs. 90 lakhs a year. A major task of the survey ships is to prepare navigational charts of all major and minor ports and make them available internationally so that ships calling at these ports can avoid underwater hazards like rocks.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 30, 1926

Development of Indian Railways

London, April 29: The Commons agreed to the motion of Mr. Waddington urging utilisation of every opportunity to develop Empire Trade. Replying to the references to India in the course of the debate, Sir. P. Cunliffe-Lister said that the development of Indian Railways must rest with the Government of India and it was unwise and improper to try to force, in the interests of this country, development which India cannot meet or which she does not require. But an impartial observer reading the Aevorth Report and speaking with those acquainted with Indian Railway administration, traveling facilities and Indian desire to travel, would agree that it was in the interest of India herself rapidly to increase her railway development. He pointed out that legislation had been passed giving a three-quarter grant of interest.

MOULQUE



Helping hand: Voters being assisted by security personnel at a polling booth in Kolkata on Wednesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Ground zero: BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari visiting a polling booth. Trinamool workers protested against him during the visit. PTI



Duty done: People showing their inked finger after casting their vote during the West Bengal elections. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Crucial polls: West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee after casting her voting in Kolkata. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

From turnout to transfers, Bengal elections marked by many firsts

Curtains down on second and final phase of polling; special intensive revision of electoral rolls and deletion of voters, security deployment, adjudication hearings, election-related transfers intensified focus on the State; result on May 4

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The West Bengal Assembly election, the second and final phase of which concluded on Wednesday, has been possibly the most-watched State polls in recent history.

While the focus now shifts to May 4, when the results will be declared, the elections have been marked by many firsts.

The first phase saw a turnout of 93.19%, while the second recorded 92.6% — the highest in the State since Independence.

Apart from voter enthusiasm, the special intensive revision of electoral rolls had a two-pronged effect on turnout figures. The removal of names of dead and shifted voters and duplicate entries shrank the voter list by 13%. At the same time, concerns over citizenship-linked voting



Lining up: People standing in a queue to cast their vote on Wednesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

rights prompted many, especially migrant workers, to return home to vote.

More than 2.3 lakh Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) personnel, 38,297 State police personnel, 142 general observers, 95 police observers, 100 expenditure observers, and several teams of the National

Investigative Agency have been deployed in the State.

Under the SIR process, voters flagged under the “logical discrepancy” category were checked against a highly contentious five-point list even if they were mapped to the 2002 SIR list.

After the EC hearings,

nearly 60 lakh of approximately 1.5 crore cases remained disputed due to disagreement between the Electoral Registration Officers and micro-observers appointed by the poll panel. This led to over 60 lakh names being placed under “adjudication” category and excluded from

voting pending verification.

The Supreme Court in March took an “extraordinary” decision to involve the judiciary in the SIR process saying a persistent “trust deficit” between the Mamata Banerjee government and the EC had led to a “stalemate”, with time running out.

The court-appointed judicial officers reviewed the disputed cases and struck down 27 lakh of them. The tribunals had, till Tuesday night, cleared 1,607 people of the 27 lakh. The remaining cases hang in limbo.

This poll season, West Bengal saw the highest number of election-related transfers, with 483 officials shifted during the poll period against just 23 transfers across all other poll-bound States put together.

According to the EC, seizures of illicit inducements crossed ₹510 crore.

70,000 CAPF personnel will remain in Bengal until further orders: poll body

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

As many as 700 companies or 70,000 personnel of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) will remain deployed in West Bengal till “further orders”, an official of the Election Commission said.

The deployment plan was finalised and issued on March 19, and the 70,000 personnel will continue to remain in the State for security arrangements and law and order duties, the official said.

In an X post, the Director-General of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), G.P. Singh, said that, as stated earlier, “500 companies of CAPF would stay in Bengal, after the polling, till further orders”. He was referring to his previous post on April 25, in which he said: “It has also been conveyed to all Force Commanders that 500 Companies of CAPF would remain stationed in



Offering aid: An elderly woman being assisted by a CAPF member at a polling booth in Hooghly on Wednesday. ANI

Bengal after the election process, till further orders.”

Mr. Singh had shared an extract of the order which said that 200 companies of the CRPF; 150 of the Border Security Force (BSF); and 50 each of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), and the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) would remain deployed in the State.

According to an internal communication of the CRPF, the nodal force for all CAPFs for election-relat-

ed deployment, 230 companies of the CRPF or 23,000 personnel would be de-inducted from Thursday. The CRPF companies would return to Jammu and Kashmir, their original place of deployment, the order said. Another 388 companies of the State Armed Police, comprising about 38,000 personnel, would be sent back to other States.

In all, immediately after the second phase of polling, around 61,000 out of 2.4 lakh personnel are being moved out of the State.

Raghav loses followers on Instagram after AAP exit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha member Raghav Chadha, who broke away from the AAP and joined the BJP, began losing followers on Instagram within a day of his exit. Mr. Chadha, popular on social media, lost 1.1 million followers by April 25, a day after his exit. He lost another one million by Wednesday.

While he had 14.6 million followers on the day he announced his departure, his count stood at 12.1 million on Wednesday.

AAP spokesperson Priyanka Kakkar said: “Now it’s just the social media downfall of Mr. Chadha. The people will teach all the seven traitors a lesson they will not forget”.

Modi inaugurates 594-km Ganga Expressway in Uttar Pradesh, praises overall development

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday inaugurated the 594-km Ganga Expressway in Hardoi, describing it as the identity of a “new Uttar Pradesh”, which would emerge as a new lifeline for the State’s connectivity and employment.

Hailing the development of the State, Mr. Modi added, “In Uttar Pradesh today, not only are expressways being built, but the overall development is also progressing at an even faster pace.”

“The Ganga Expressway is not merely a road project, but the foundation of Uttar Pradesh’s economic, social, and industrial transformation in which development is moving ahead



Grand opening: Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the inauguration of the Ganga Expressway in Hardoi on Wednesday. ANI

even faster than the speed of the expressway itself. People can now reach the Sangam in a few hours and visit Kashi for darshan,” he said.

Inaugurating the project built at an approximate cost of ₹36,230 crore, he said the six-lane access-

controlled expressway was likely to significantly reduce travel time, making the journey from Meerut to Prayagraj possible in about six hours. The expressway would begin from Meerut and pass through Hapur, Bulandshahr, Amroha, Sambhal, Badaun, Shahja-

hanpur, Hardoi, Unnao, Rae Bareilly, and Pratapgarh before culminating in Prayagraj.

“Previously, farmers’ produce could not reach markets promptly, but now, with the expressway, products will arrive at markets more quickly, thereby increasing farmers’ income,” Mr. Modi said.

Uttar Pradesh was experiencing significant infrastructure development with remarkable advancements in expressways, airports, industrial corridors, and defence manufacturing.

Swift progress

“Initiatives like the BrahMos missile project are providing a new identity to the State’s industrial capabilities. Uttar Pradesh is swiftly progressing towards becoming a one-tril-

lion-dollar economy. With fresh opportunities in investment, industry, and employment, the State’s reputation has evolved, making it a key destination for investors,” the Prime Minister said.

He slammed the Opposition parties, primarily the Congress and the Samajwadi Party, for being “anti-women” and opposing the women’s reservation amendment Bill.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said the expressway would serve as a major medium for the progress of farmers, employment for youth, preservation of faith and culture, and the prosperity of Uttar Pradesh.

Earlier, the Prime Minister held a roadshow in Varanasi drawing large crowds along the route.

Jaishankar speaks with Araghchi days after BRICS logjam

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

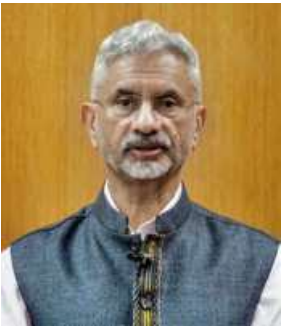
Days after an India-led meeting among BRICS envoys failed to reach a consensus on the conflict in West Asia, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and his Iranian counterpart, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, spoke over phone on Wednesday.

Following the conversation that is part of the preparatory steps ahead of BRICS ministerial meeting that will be held here next month, the Iranian embassy here said that the two Ministers discussed the current Iran-U.S. ceasefire as well as “bilateral, regional and international issues”.

“Had a detailed conversation about various aspects of the current situation. We agreed to remain in close touch,” said Mr. Jaishankar after receiving the call from Mr. Araghchi. The Iranian Minister had visited Pakistan, Oman and Russia in the past five days to find a “workable framework” to resolve the conflict that erupted on February 28.

The Embassy of Iran said the two Ministers “discussed and exchanged views on the latest developments related to the ceasefire, bilateral relations, as well as regional and international issues”.

The conversation indicates continuity in high-level contacts despite the fact that a meeting of Deputy Foreign Ministers and Special Envoys from BRICS and MENA (Middle East North Africa) held here last week failed to reach a consensus on the crisis as



S. Jaishankar

member countries had differing positions on matters such as Israel’s involvement in the conflict.

The Hindu had reported that the envoys could not reach a consensus because of differences between Iran and the UAE, as well as India’s desire to dilute the language about the Israel-Palestine conflict. The BRICS dialogue is part of the preparatory exchanges that are taking place ahead of the Ministerial meeting that will take place here next month.

Russia has indicated that Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov will attend the BRICS Ministerial meeting in New Delhi. “On the 14th and 15th of May, the Foreign Minister of the Russian Federation Sergei Lavrov will participate in a full-fledged session or council, of the foreign ministries of BRICS countries in New Delhi. This session under the Indian presidency will become a good opportunity for detailed and profound discussion of relevant issues of international agenda,” said Maria Zacharova, spokesperson of the Russian Foreign Ministry on Wednesday.

Mr. Araghchi’s participation is yet to be confirmed.

Nicobar project is destruction dressed as development: Rahul

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Great Nicobar Island project is “one of the biggest scams... the largest theft of Indian property” that is being undertaken to fulfil the “fantasies of one businessman” despite the damage it will do to India’s ecology, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said on Wednesday.

Mr. Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, who was on the island on Tuesday, said in a video statement, “What is happening here is that all these trees are going to be cut with total disregard for people who live here, with total disregard for the dam-

age this will do to India’s ecology. So that one businessman, Mr. Adani, can fulfil his fantasies.”

He said that “millions of trees marked for the axe” in the “160 sq. km of rain-forest” are “condemned to die” as part of the ₹92,000-crore project to build an international transshipment port, an airport, and a tourism-centric township.

‘Biggest scam’

“This is not development. This is destruction dressed in development’s language,” he said, adding that the project is “one of the biggest scams and gravest crimes against this country’s natural and tribal heritage in our life-



Listening to concerns: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi interacting with people in Campbell Bay on Tuesday. ANI

time”. “It must be stopped. And it can be stopped - if Indians choose to see what I have seen,” he said.

Mr. Gandhi spent a day in Great Nicobar, meeting

local Nicobarese tribal communities, settlers and ex-servicemen families. His visit came amid protests by the Nicobarese communities against clear-

ances granted to the project. They have alleged that their forest rights had not been settled and have expressed apprehensions about losing access to their ancestral villages, and the forests.

‘In a hidden manner’

“Every single person who lives here is against this project, none of them has been asked about it, and they do not know about the compensation they are supposed to receive. This is being done in a hidden manner, surreptitiously. Now, I know why the government did not want me to come here,” he said.

While the National Green Tribunal, earlier this

year, cleared the project, noting that the Union government had considered all possible damage to the ecology and had taken efforts to compensate for it, a challenge to the clearance is pending in the Calcutta High Court.

The court is hearing allegations that consent procedures for the project had been violated and that forest rights had not been settled. It is expected to hear the matter next in May.

The Congress leader’s visit came weeks after a delegation of leaders from the Tribal Council of Little and Great Nicobar met with him in New Delhi to raise concerns about the project.

M CH-CHE

oil marketing companies (OMCs) are selling petrol and diesel at a loss of ₹14 per litre and ₹18 per litre, respectively, as elevated crude prices outpace capped retail fuel rates, squeezing marketing margins. Besides losses on petrol and diesel, the elevated energy prices post West Asia crisis are likely to leave companies with an under recovery of ₹80,000 crore on cooking gas LPG in the current fiscal, while fertiliser subsidy is projected to rise to ₹2.05 to 2.25 lakh crore. Rating agency ICRA said supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have tightened availability of fuels, fertilisers and chemicals, pushing up prices and increasing cost pressures across downstream industries. Crude prices before the West Asia crisis broke out were around \$70-72 a barrel. "The stable pump prices for auto fuels amid elevated crude oil prices are impacting the profitability of the OMCs," said Prashant Vasishit, Senior VP and Co-Group Head, ICRA. PTI

Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), gross domestic production of natural gas was 2,874 million metric standard cubic metre (MMSCM) during the month. This was 4.9% lower on a year-on-year basis.

Natural gas producers use some quantity of the overall gas produced for in-

Overall, according to the provisional data, the total gas available for consumption, inclusive of both imports and domestic production, stood at 5,726 MMSCM, although PPAC cautions the actual figure could be “much lower” owing to the situation in West Asia.

Dr. Susan M. Engel is a professor of psychology at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. She is also a senior research advisor at the Center for the Study of Social Design. Dr. Engel's research focuses on the development of social skills in children and adolescents with autism spectrum disorders.

She lauded India's Aadhaar experiment but added that the U.K. will not walk that path, though it is looking for a universal identification system. "What you have done with Aadhaar is really impressive. But I can't say that we

Ms. Langley visited New Delhi and Mumbai from April 25 to April 29, where she met industry leaders, government officials and Ministers.

Speaking of the barriers in the success of the long-awaited Free Trade Agreement, she said that the British companies still lacked an understanding of the Indian markets and their potential. "Even with the FTA, we need case studies and real success stories to make the FTA work to encourage people to invest in both directions," she said, emphasising on the need to highlight the success stories from India and the U.K.

Homologation is the official certification process ensuring a vehicle, or its components, complies with government technical, safety, and environmental regulations before it can be sold or used on public roads.

"At the end of the day, after all the good intention, the corporate is going to look at the EBITDA and profit, that is what the stock market and shareholder are going to recognise. Therefore, we will have to convert each of these opportunities into an economically viable product," he stated, adding the government would also have to go along with the effort.



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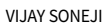
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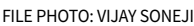
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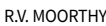
We don't talk to our players about being fearless: RCB's Flower



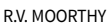
Kohli is someone who can win a game on his own: GT's Parthiv



No target is beyond reach this season: Gavaskar on IPL run-fest



Suryavanshi the fastest to reach 400 runs in an IPL season



Titans seek home comfort against Royal Challengers

TraviShek, Klaasen run riot as SRH bags fifth successive win

RCB has an all-weather attack, reckons head coach Flower

India goes down to China

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Punjab FC defends AIFF Elite Youth League title

Three second-half goals within 10 minutes saw Punjab FC defend its AIFF Elite Youth League title, securing a 3-0 victory over Zinc Football Academy in the final at Garhshankar on Tuesday.

The result: Punjab FC 3 (Karish Soram 69, Vishal Yadav 70, Thongram Rishikanta Singh 79) bt Zinc FA 0.

Harika claims 69kg gold in C'wealth junior weightlifting

Bellana Harika, with 197kg (86kg+111kg), won the 69kg gold at the Commonwealth youth and junior weightlifting in Apia on Wednesday. Karangi Tharangini (79kg+100kg, 179kg) and Bhumika Mohite (109kg+86kg, 195kg) won silver in the 63kg events. In Universal Cup, Abhishek Nipane (140kg+184kg, 324kg) won the 88kg silver.

Second Bangladesh-NZ T20I washed out

The second T20 between Bangladesh and New Zealand was washed out due to persistent rain in Chattogram on Wednesday. The match was called off without a ball being bowled.

Sri Lanka government to take over SLC administration

Sri Lanka government on Wednesday decided to take over the administration of the country's cricket board after the resignation of its president Shammi Silva and the executive committee. Sri Lanka Cricket chief Silva and other office-bearers stepped down on Tuesday.

28-day Bengaluru summer racing season from May 1

About 634 horses, including nine outstation, will take part in the 28-day Bengaluru summer season that will run from May 1 to July 31. L. Shivashankar, chairman & senior steward of the Bangalore Turf Club, said total prize money, including trophies, of ₹20.35 crore is estimated to be paid during the summer meeting and it would be approximately ₹21.53 crore including divisions. Zavaray S. Poonawalla and the Bangalore Turf Club Ltd. will jointly sponsor the four classic races while Wayne Wood has been appointed as chief stipendiary steward.

Board of Appeal: Vivek G. Ubhayakar (chairman), Y. Jagannath, K. Jayaram, Rajan Chona, Ritesh Kumar Singh IAS, Satish N. Gowda and Seemant Kumar Singh IPS.

AROUND THE CITY



Say cheese! CSK leg-spinner Rahul Chahar clicks a picture with the Super Kings Academy trainees. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Take Sports clinches title

Take Sports defeated Fearless Fighters by six runs in the final to clinch the Master Cricket Club Iron Lady Trophy.

The scores: **Final:** Take Sports 91/9 in 20 overs (M. Gokulnandhini 3/18) bt Fearless Fighters 85/9 in 20 overs (Arunadevi Sekar 37, S. Sadhana Sri 3/19).

Special awards: **Best batter:** Arunadevi (Fearless Fighters); **Best bowler:** Selca (Take Sports); **Best wicket-keeper:** Akshal (Take Sports); **Player-of-the-Tournament:** Swagatha (Take Sports).

Rahul Chahar visits revamped SKA centre
Chennai Super Kings leg-spinner Rahul Chahar visited the revamped Super Kings Academy (SKA) centre at Guru Nanak College, where he

interacted with young trainees and shared insights about his cricket journey. Louis Mariano, SKA director of cricket, and M. Raja, zonal head coach, were also present. Addressing the gathering, Chahar emphasised the value of effort over outcomes. “The only thing that is in your hands is hard work,” he said, urging youngsters to make the most of their formative years.

Super Kings Academy camp from May 1 to 31
The Super Kings Academy (SKA) will conduct its summer cricket coaching camp across six centres in Chennai from May 1 to 31. The camp, open to boys and girls aged six to 23, will be held at



Young champs: Kridhay, right, and Alankrithaashri with their big prizes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Thoraipakkam (7305322282), Velachery (Guru Nanak College – 6379389646), Porur (Sri Ramachandra Medical College – 9361839587), Vanagaram (SV High School – 7305612157), Injambakkam (Akshar Arbol International School – 9940077942), and Ottiambakkam (MS Dhoni Global School – 6379389646). Interested participants can contact the respective

centres or visit the academy's official website (www.superkingsacademy.com) for further details.

Kridhay and Alankrithaashri crowned u-7 champions
A. Kridhay of Salem and D. Alankrithaashri from Tiruvallur bagged the open and girls' titles with eight points from nine rounds in the 38th Tamil Nadu State u-7 chess championship on

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Khicha Kvaratskhelia and Ousmane Dembele scored twice each as Paris Saint-Germain beat Bayern Munich 5-4 in an epic first leg of their Champions League semifinal on Tuesday, an extraordinary encounter becoming the highest-scoring match ever at this stage of the competition.

The first half alone was crazy, with Harry Kane giving Bayern the lead from a penalty only for Kvaratskhelia to equalise before Joao Neves headed the hosts in front at an enthralled Parc des Princes. Michael Olise made it



Goal glut: Kvaratskhelia, second right, scores PSG's opener against Bayern. AP

2-2, but a Dembele penalty in first-half stoppage time had the reigning champion back ahead at the interval. Kvaratskhelia, surely the standout player in this sea-

son's Champions League, and Dembele both then scored again to have PSG seemingly out of sight, only for Dayot Upamecano to pull one back before Luis

Diaz made it 5-4.

An unforgettable game – perhaps better even than last season's semifinal between Inter Milan and Barcelona – leaves the tie bet-

ween the continent's two best teams of the moment wonderfully poised for next Wednesday's return at the Allianz Arena, with a place in the final in Budap-

est on May 30 on the line.

Luis Enrique's Parisians will be returning to Munich – scene of their 5-0 win over Inter in last year's final – with the advantage, but Bayern will be confident it can overturn the narrow deficit at home.

The French champion is seeking to become just the second side in the modern Champions League era to retain the trophy, while the German champion is hoping to reach the final for the first time since 2020, when it defeated PSG to lift the trophy for the sixth time.

The result (semifinal, first leg):
Paris Saint-Germain 5 (Kvaratskhelia 24, 56, Neves 33, Dembele 45+5-pen, 58) bt Bayern Munich 4 (Kane 17-pen, Olise 41, Upamecano 65, Diaz 68).

New Zealand names star trio for Women's T20 WC defence

CRICKET

Agence France-Presse
WELLINGTON

Retiring New Zealand cricket greats Sophie Devine, Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuu were named on Wednesday in the White Ferns' Women's T20 World Cup squad for their “final mission” of defending the title. New Zealand will play the West Indies, Sri Lanka, Ireland, Scotland and England in its group.

The 15-member squad is led by star all-rounder Amelia Kerr and features 10 players who won the title in Dubai in 2024, beating South Africa in the final.

Devine, Bates and Tahuu had all announced they would retire after the World Cup, which takes place in England and Wales in June-July.

All-rounder Nat Sciver-Brunt will lead the 15-member England squad, the ECB announced on Tues-



One last time: Tahuu, Bates and Devine are on their “final mission” to defend the title. FILE PHOTO

day. The same England squad, led by Sciver-Brunt, will also feature in the preceding series against India and New Zealand in May-June. This will be Sciver-Brunt's seventh appearance at global T20 event.

The India women's team will tour England for three T20Is and a one-off Test at Lord's. The T20Is are scheduled for late May/early June, while the Test match runs from July 10 to 13, marking 50 years since the first England women's

match at the hallowed venue.

The squads: **New Zealand:** Amelia Kerr (Capt.), Suzie Bates, Sophie Devine, Flora Devonshire, Izzy Gaze, Maddy Green, Brooke Halliday, Bree Illing, Polly Inglis, Jess Kerr, Rosemary Mair, Nensi Patel, Georgia Plimmer, Izzy Sharp, Lea Tahuu.

England: Nat Sciver-Brunt (Capt.), Lauren Bell, Alice Capsey, Tilly Corteen-Coleman, Charlie Dean, Sophia Dunkley, Sophie Ecclestone, Lauren Filer, Dani Gibson, Amy Jones, Freya Kemp, Heather Knight, Linsey Smith, Issy Wong, Danni Wyatt-Hodge.

I am trying to find a solution: Shakib still hopeful of returning to Bangladesh side

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

Shakib Al Hasan has been away from international cricket for nearly a couple of years, but the former Bangladesh captain remains optimistic about a return to the national side despite ongoing uncertainty surrounding his future.

Speaking to *The Hindu* on Wednesday, Shakib acknowledged the unpredictability of the situation back home while keeping his hopes alive.

“The situation in Bangladesh can change all of a sudden. You never know what happens tomorrow, so that's why I'm still hopeful,” Shakib said.

While maintaining a calm outlook, he admitted that his comeback was not entirely in his hands. “I don't think too much about what will happen. Every day, I'm trying to



Shakib. FILE PHOTO

move forward in a new way. As far as making it back to the Bangladesh team is concerned, I don't think it's in my control. But, I'm trying to find a solution,” Shakib, whose last Test match was against India in Kanpur in 2024, explained.

In the city for the jersey launch of the EUT20 Belgium, Shakib also shed light on his recent interaction with his long-time teammate and friend, Tamim Iqbal, who is now serving

as the interim president of the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB). Despite their conversation, there has been no progress regarding his return.

The veteran all-rounder did not hold back while criticising both the BCB and the previous interim government over the team's absence from the T20 World Cup in India earlier this year, a decision taken over security concerns.

Bad decision

“It was a very bad decision from the then government, and at the same time, the BCB, too, played along, taking a strong stance. And, in the end, the players suffered,” he said.

“If the BCB had an issue with the BCCI over certain issues, they should have sorted it out, rather than burning the bridge with the ICC. That was terrible.”

Golfer Vijay Kumar passes away

Sports Bureau
HYDERABAD

Veteran Indian golfer Vijay Kumar passed away in his hometown of Lucknow, following a heart attack on Wednesday. He was 57.

A winner of the 2002 Indian Open and a four-time Order of Merit winner, Vijay was widely regarded as one of the most accomplished and respected figures in Indian professional golf.

His victory at the 2002 Indian Open remains one of the defining moments in Indian golf history.

Vijay is among a select group of just nine Indian golfers to have claimed the prestigious title. He also represented India at the Alfred Dunhill Cup in 1999 at St. Andrew's.

Skill and consistency
Known for his exceptional skill, consistency, competitive spirit, and exemplary sportsmanship, Vijay inspired generations of golfers and played a significant role in shaping the sport's growth in India.

Kapil Dev, president, Professional Golf Tour of India, expressed his condolences.



Vijay with the 2002 Indian Open trophy. FILE PHOTO: V.V. KRISHNAN

Vijay won the Indian Open in 2002 and is among a select group of nine Indian golfers to have claimed the title. He is a four-time Order of Merit winner.

Vijay also represented India at the Alfred Dunhill Cup in 1999 at St. Andrew's

“Vijay Kumar was one of the true stalwarts of Indian golf. His achievements, humility, and dedication to the sport made him a role model for generations. His passing is a great loss to Indian golf, and we extend our heartfelt sympathies to his family and loved ones.”



Vivek Krishnan

The year was 2018. Amit Vashisht, a coach who has been running the Sporting Cricket Club for nearly two decades, happened to be watching a game of tennis-ball cricket in his neighbourhood in Najafgarh – a modest town on the outskirts of Delhi that gained prominence on the cricketing map when Virender Sehwag emerged on the scene.

As the contest unfolded, Vashisht’s eyes fell on a skinny youngster who was hurling in yorkers at brisk pace. The run-up to the crease was rhythmical, the arm-speed quick, and the bowling action smooth. Vashisht instantly felt the urge to take the lad under his wings at his academy. That was Prince Yadav, the Lucknow Super Giants quick who has been making strides in the IPL over the past year. In his debut campaign in 2025, the pacer from Delhi provided a teaser over six games without the numbers corroborating his capability – he snared only three breakthroughs at an economy rate of 9.85. This year, the promise has been substantiated by performance, with Prince scalping 13 wickets in eight outings at an economy rate of 8.06 so far. If there is one game that embodies his excellence, it is the duel against the red-hot Punjab Kings in New Chandigarh on April 19, where his figures of 4-0-25-2 were at odds with the shellacking that the other bowlers received as Shreyas Iyer and Co. hammered a humongous total of 254 for seven.

Basics in place

Even as the franchise’s results have plummeted, Prince has continued to stand out as a source of hope, thanks largely to the 24-year-old’s inherent ability to nail the yorker. In addition, the native of Daryapur Khurd, a village around 10 kilometres from Najafgarh, can crank it up to 145kmph on the speed gun or take the pace off as he deems fit. Learning the slower variations came later, but he had most of his fundamentals in place even before he held a cricket ball for the first time.

“As a coach, I know what to look for in a pace bowler. The rhythm should be

Prince Yadav: the yorker-specialist looking to rule the big stage

The pace bowler from Delhi has taken giant strides for Lucknow Super Giants in the IPL over the past year after starting out with the tennis ball. A two-year ban by the BCCI for age-fudging in 2019 looked set to derail his professional career just when it had begun, but the youngster has rallied against the odds to reach this far

for his appearances. Bowling with a softer ball had become muscle memory, but when the time came to switch to the leather ball, he was quick to adapt.

“If someone is bowling yorkers consistently with the tennis ball, a bit of practice is enough to adjust to the leather ball in my view,” Vashisht opined. “When he made the switch, I would give him small targets. I would ask him to bowl 24 balls at one length, then 18 balls at another length and drills like that. His grasping power was very good. His fitness levels were also good.”

Not convinced

Despite these ingredients, Prince’s father wasn’t convinced. Conforming to the stereotype of a strict dad in a patriarchal setting, Ram Niwas Yadav wanted his only son and the youngest of three children to abandon the cricket field and focus on academics. It wasn’t a feeling borne by an aversion to the sport, but instead a reflection of the pragmatism prevalent in most Indian households.

“There is so much competition in cricket that I used to think that it would be impossible for Prince to make the cut,” said Ram Niwas, who served in the Railway Protection Special Force and then took to farming after retirement. “But he was obsessed with cricket. He would play even three tennis-ball matches in a day. He was an intelligent kid. He could have been good at studies. His teacher used to tell us that his mind is very sharp. I was very clear that I wasn’t going to go to anyone seeking favours for his cricket. I never went to anyone in my own career. Whatever he had to do had to be on merit.”

The father’s wish was for Prince to get into the police. “Upon my insisting that he should give the Delhi Police Constable exam, he agreed. He didn’t qualify in the merit list but just passed the written test. He didn’t appear for the physical examination. His mind wasn’t there.”

It was when Prince stuck to his guns and got selected for the Delhi Under-19 team in 2019 that the 61-year-old had a slight change of heart. It helped the senior figure realise that his offspring must be blessed with some aptitude to reach even this far. Prince went on to claim 10 wickets in eight matches in the 2019-20 Vinoo Mankad Trophy – an annual Under-19 One-Day tournament organised by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) – to finish as Delhi’s second-highest wicket-taker.

Delhi’s current bowling coach V. Arvind was with the U-19 set-up at that time. “At U-19 level, he wasn’t very effective in

red-ball cricket. But he was very good with the white ball in the Vinoo Mankad Trophy. The thing that I liked about him even then was his attitude. He is a typical Najafgarh kid with a never-say-die attitude. He used to enjoy bowling the final few overs of a game,” Arvind recollected.

Curveball

Just as things seemed to be falling in place, however, a curveball was thrown in Prince’s direction in December 2019 when he was banned by the BCCI for two years for age-fudging. For the bowler’s well-wishers, the suspension felt like “a death in the family”.

“He performed well for the U-19 team. After that, Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) had called him for IPL trials to



There is so much competition in cricket that I used to think that it would be impossible for Prince to make the cut. But he was obsessed with cricket. He would play even three tennis-ball matches in a day

RAM NIWAS
Prince Yadav’s father

Bengaluru. Just as he reached there, the news of his ban appeared. It came as a big shock,” revealed Ram Niwas, his voice bearing a trace of sadness as he looks back. “He was heartbroken, but he bounced back. During the Covid pandemic, he would sweat it out in practice almost all day. He would come home for just two or three hours in the afternoon to eat food. He just started working extremely hard. He became fiercely determined that he has to achieve something as a cricketer.”

Cognisant of the setback that Prince had encountered, Vashisht sought the assistance of Sangwan. “During his ban, I asked Pradeep to help Prince. I told Pradeep that the boy has the talent to play at a higher level. Pradeep worked more on fitness with Prince and ensured that he stayed motivated during the ban. I didn’t want Prince to feel deflated that his career is finished,” said the 44-year-old coach.

While many youngsters tend to fall by the wayside after such a jolt, the impression that Prince had left on the coaches and administrators in Delhi during his U-19 stint held him in good stead once his ban was served.

“He was off the radar for a while. But the thing was that everyone knew he was good. So when his ban was lifted, it didn’t

take long for him to be picked for the senior Delhi team,” said Arvind.

Prince made his debut for Delhi in the Ranji Trophy in the 2023-24 season. In his first appearance, against Jammu & Kashmir in Jammu in January 2024, the visiting side didn’t bowl at all as the drawn game was confined to 42 overs of play over four days due to inclement weather. In his next outing later that month, Prince displayed good control against Uttarakhand in Chandigarh, but returned just one wicket in 33 overs across two innings.

It wasn’t exactly an impressive initiation to the senior level at a time when the likes of Harshit Rana and Mayank Yadav were also making headway in the national capital. But before any uncertainty could creep in about his peers marching ahead, the inaugural season of the Delhi Premier League was launched in mid-2024.

Prince turned out for a team led by Rishabh Pant, and claimed 13 wickets in 10 matches. It paved the way for further opportunities for Delhi in the Vijay Hazare Trophy and the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy during the 2024-25 domestic season, and facilitated the transition from being a net bowler at LSG to earning a ₹30 lakh contract for the same franchise ahead of the 2025 edition.

Content as he may be by the change in circumstances, it hasn’t stopped Prince from refining his skills. In the 2025-26 Vijay Hazare Trophy, the domestic 50-over meet that was held in Bengaluru last December and January, he effected 18 dismissals in eight matches. He has continued his upward trajectory in his second IPL season this year.

“When he played two Ranji games in the 2023-24 season, I felt he wasn’t quite suited to red-ball cricket because he is not the kind of bowler who gets extra bounce. But when we played the Vijay Hazare tournament in Bengaluru recently, he was really effective, getting sharp bounce on those pitches at the Centre of Excellence. The confidence from playing in the IPL is visible in him. He has improved a lot compared to two or three years ago,” Arvind observed.

If Prince does not veer from this path, Arvind senses that an India-A call-up in white-ball cricket may not be far away. “He can move the ball both ways, and he is very accurate. Because he is a skiddy bowler, he has a lethal bouncer that the batter finds difficult to evade in white-ball cricket,” he analysed. “Given the way he is bowling, I am sure that the national selectors will give him a break soon for India-A.”



THE GIST

Even as LSG’s fortunes have plummeted, Prince has continued to stand out as a source of hope, thanks largely to his inherent ability to nail the yorker

While many youngsters tend to fall by the wayside after such a jolt, the impression that Prince had left on the coaches and administrators in Delhi during his U-19 stint held him in good stead once his ban was served

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The thing that I liked about him even then (under-19 level) was his attitude. He is a typical Najafgarh kid with a never-say-die attitude. He used to enjoy bowling the final few overs of a game

ARVIND
Delhi bowling coach

good while running to the crease, the arm-speed should be good and the action should be clean. I saw all these things in Prince,” Vashisht, who has also trained former India Under-19 World Cup winner Pradeep Sangwan, told *The Hindu*. “He was also bowling good yorkers. I felt that I won’t have to work a lot on him. He had all the basics in place. When I saw him for the first time, I was convinced then and there that this is a talent who I will work with to help him progress.”

Having been drawn into the tennis-ball circuit by the age of 12 or 13, so proficient had Prince become at targeting the toes of batters that he was eventually travelling to other parts of the country and getting paid anywhere between ₹500 to ₹1000

How decentralising therapy can support mental health treatment

Antidepressants are increasingly being prescribed by general physicians, often in busy settings; if a clinician has limited follow-up and no access to psychosocial services, medication becomes the most feasible intervention, and over time reinforces both clinical habits and patient expectations

Jeel Vasa
Richa Shete
Madhurima Vuddemary

India continues to face a large mental health treatment gap, with nearly 85% of individuals with common mental disorders receiving no formal care. However, over the past decade, access to antidepressant medication, especially drugs called selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors (SSRIs), has improved, marking an important shift toward making treatment more available.

This expansion is important because, for moderate to severe depression, antidepressants are not optional but often essential. For many patients, they remain one of the most effective and life-changing interventions available.

The concern, therefore, is not about medications themselves. It is about how, when, and for whom they are being used in routine practice. Emerging evidence suggests that a significant proportion of prescriptions either occur without a clear diagnosis of major depression, particularly in primary care settings, or have poor follow-up.

The Indian Psychiatric Society recommends a stepped-care model, where people with milder issues are first managed with psychosocial interventions before initiating pharmacotherapy. Yet in practice, this step is often bypassed and medication becomes the first-line response even in situations where other approaches may be more appropriate.

Consequences of routine prescribing

The distinction between distress and disorder is important. In busy clinics, this may blur. Patients present with sleep problems, work stress, interpersonal conflicts, or grief. These experiences are real and often impairing, and deserve attention. Even when they do not meet the threshold for clinical depression, they may still require psychological support. They are not always best addressed through medication alone, especially when they are closely tied to identifiable life circumstances.

Routine prescribing in such scenarios is understandable. It offers a quick, tangible intervention in systems where time is limited and follow-up uncertain, whether the presentation is mild depression or distress that does not meet diagnostic thresholds. However, when medication becomes the default response, we risk shifting focus away from understanding context and towards suppressing the symptoms.

Antidepressants are not addictive in the conventional sense. They do not cause cravings, people do not feel the need to keep increasing the dose, and they do not lead to compulsive use. These details are important and must be clear, especially for patients who benefit from them. However, discontinuation symptoms are well-known, with some individuals experiencing dizziness, sleep disturbances, or sensory symptoms when attempting to stop.

This concern has been reflected in recent policy discussions, including a U.K. House of Lords debate, which highlighted issues of long-term antidepressant use, withdrawal difficulties, and the need for better prescribing guidance and tapering support.

On the other hand, sleeping pills that are usually prescribed alongside antidepressant medications complicate the problem. They are frequently co-prescribed for sleep or anxiety and can be effective in the short term. Unlike antidepressants, however, they can lead to true dependence, where the body gets used to them, higher doses may be needed over time, and stopping them can be difficult. With longer use, they carry risks of dependence, cognitive slowing, and difficult withdrawal. Patients are also often unaware of the risks of these medications.

Over time, patterns emerge. What begins as short-term symptomatic treatment can extend into prolonged use, particularly in the absence of structured follow-up. In such instances, patients may continue medication not because it is still clearly indicated, but because stopping it has become difficult.

There is also a less visible cost. When treatment is centred primarily around medication, opportunities to develop coping strategies, address maladaptive thinking, and engage with underlying stressors may be reduced. Many individuals with mild to moderate symptoms benefit significantly with addition of brief psychological interventions such as behavioural activation or problem-solving therapy,



The Indian Psychiatric Society recommends a stepped-care model, where people with milder issues are first managed with psychosocial interventions before initiating pharmacotherapy. MIKA BAUMEISTER/UNSPLASH

including structured models like the ‘Healthy Activity Program’, which has been effective in Indian primary-care settings. These approaches reduce symptoms and build skills that persist beyond the treatment period.

Little choice

It is tempting to frame this as just overprescription by doctors. In reality, it reflects a deeper structural issue.

India has a limited mental health workforce, and psychotherapy remains concentrated in urban and specialist settings. In many parts of the country, particularly in rural and semi-urban areas, pharmacological treatment is the only consistently available form of care. When alternatives are scarce, prescribing becomes less a choice and more a necessity.

Public health programmes illustrate this imbalance. Access to screening and medication have improved but the availability of structured psychotherapy remains uneven. Continuity of care is difficult to maintain across districts; even where frameworks exist, implementation varies widely. This shortage is further reflected in the limited number of formal psychotherapy training positions, such as M.Phil seats, which remain insufficient relative to the population’s needs.

Antidepressants are also increasingly being prescribed by general physicians and non-psychiatric practitioners, often in busy settings with limited time. If a clinician has ten minutes, limited follow-up, and no access to psychosocial services, medication becomes the most feasible intervention, and over time reinforces both clinical habits and patient expectations.

Where options are available, prescribing patterns tend to shift even in non-psychiatric practitioners, with reduced reliance on antidepressants. This suggests that clinicians do incorporate these options when they are accessible. Thus, if psychotherapy were more easily available, many patients could be referred for it, sometimes even before medication.

Therapy beyond the clinic

Expanding access to psychotherapy can’t rely solely on increasing specialists’ numbers, which is a slow and resource-intensive process. Decentralising psychotherapy offers a more immediate pathway, based on identifying core, evidence-based components of psychological support that can be delivered by trained non-specialists within community settings.

There is growing evidence to support this approach. In low- and middle-income countries, brief interventions delivered by non-trained counsellors, such as

India has a limited mental health workforce, and psychotherapy remains concentrated in specialist settings. In many semi-urban and rural areas, pharmacological treatment is the only consistently available form of care. When alternatives are scarce, prescribing becomes more a necessity

behavioural activation, problem-solving, and psychoeducation, have demonstrated meaningful reductions in depression and anxiety. In 2006, after losing a patient who could not afford to travel for care, a senior psychiatrist, Dixon Chibanda in Zimbabwe, recognised the need to take mental health services into communities rather than wait for patients to reach hospitals. The Friendship Bench in Zimbabwe trained old women to deliver structured therapy to people with mild levels of mental distress on park benches, showing reductions of almost 43% on depression scales within six months. In India, the ‘Atmiyata’ programme uses community volunteers to provide basic emotional support and identify individuals who may need referral, linking local care with formal services.

These interventions are intentionally simple. Skills like active listening, validation, sleep hygiene, and structured activity scheduling can be manual and scaled up, and delivered in schools, workplaces, primary care centres, and community groups, bringing support closer to where people actually live and struggle. When these approaches are adapted to local culture, they become easier to understand and accept. Using familiar language, social roles, and everyday examples helps people engage with care more naturally.

Nearly 85% of people don’t access formal care and turn elsewhere for help. A significant fraction seek help from faith-based healers, traditional practitioners or community elders, who often serve as the first point of contact for distress. Rather than viewing this in opposition to medical care, there is value in engaging with these systems, especially for distress, while building pathways to identify and refer more severe afflictions to formal mental health services.

At the same time, limits must be clear. Complex conditions, trauma-focused therapies, and individuals at high risk require specialist expertise. Primary diagnosis and treatment of conditions such as schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, and obsessive compulsive disorder should remain within specialist care settings – but a substantial component of ongoing supportive care can be safely and

effectively task-shared within the community.

A stepped-care model can ensure decentralised care complements, rather than replaces, professional psychotherapy. Even in instances of seemingly simple distress, if the signs that an individual presents with fall outside the provider’s level of training or if they fail to improve, they must be referred in timely fashion to more expert care. Expanding non-specialist roles must overall be a cautious venture. New cadres risk overstepping competence and delaying referrals, however, underscoring the need for clear safeguards, supervision, and referral pathways.

Not less treatment

For moderate to severe depression, medications remain central and often indispensable. In many cases, the best outcomes arise from combining pharmacological treatment with psychotherapy. This integrated approach should remain the standard rather than the exception.

For milder presentations, the sequence can differ. Psychosocial interventions can be tried first, with medication introduced when needed. Even when antidepressants are started, regular review allows for dose adjustment or tapering in appropriate instances.

Training frontline providers in brief psychosocial interventions, embedding counselling within primary care, strengthening community support systems, and introducing basic prescription monitoring can collectively shift practice without major structural disruption. Digital platforms can extend this further, supporting both delivery and follow-up in areas with limited specialist access.

India has already made progress in improving access to treatment. The next step is ensuring that this access is balanced, thoughtful, and responsive to different levels of need. Medication should remain available when it is needed. But it should not be the default option, especially when it is possible to have alternatives available.

A system that offers both, clearly, appropriately, and at scale, is far more likely to serve patients well.

(Dr. Jeel Vasa, jeelvasa.98@gmail.com, is a Psychiatrist from AIIMS Nagpur. Dr. Richa Shete is an MD in Community Medicine and founder of Make A Conversation Foundation, with experience across rural, tribal, and urban mental health care. Dr. Madhurima Vuddemary is an MBBS doctor with a special interest in public health. All three are associated with the Association for Socially Applicable Research (ASAR).)



The distinctive eye-shaped spots act as a defence against predators. GETTY IMAGES

Why some marine species are speckled with ‘eyes’

Divya Gandhi

They look like eyes staring back at you daringly: butterflies have them and so do birds, to ward off predators. Now, it turns out, many marine creatures exhibit “eye spots” on their bodies as a defence against being the next meal of a shark or a large marine mammal.

A new study published in *Nature* delves into the evolutionary history of marine skates and rays to find out the origins of this visual defence.

Why do some anti-predator defences such as spots appear in some groups but are completely absent in others, the authors pondered. “Our results show that you have to look at the full range of options for avoiding predators. Eye spots evolve only under certain ecological and defensive conditions,” said lead author Madicken Åkerman, of the Department of Zoology at Stockholm University, Sweden, in a release.

This is one solution among many in the evolutionary arms race between predator and prey, he added. Prey have evolved a large array of defences to avoid predation, including mechanical, visual, chemical and behavioural traits to foil predators, said the paper.

The bombardier beetle is a classic example: it sprays a hot and toxic jet of chemicals to repel predators with startling force.

The scientists examined the co-evolution of conspicuous markings with alternative anti-predator defences and assessed their evolutionary drivers in batoids (skates and rays, superorder Batoidea), a diverse group of cartilaginous fishes comprising over 600 species. “Conspicuous markings are more commonly found in skate and ray species lacking robust anti-predator defences,” the study found.

Skates and rays have a large range of predators, including sharks, marine mammals and large fish. While some marine species develop powerful electric organs or venomous spines, others rely on camouflage, and bury themselves in the ocean bed. But smaller-bodied species, without these “weapons”, which live in sun-lit shallow waters less than 200 metres deep, were far more likely to develop bold spots or “eyespots,” the authors found.

“Eyespots are far from random. They tend to evolve in species that lack strong physical defences, such as venomous tail stings or electric shocks, and that live in bright, shallow waters where visual signals are effective,” said senior author J.L. Fitzpatrick in a release.

Interestingly, research found that eyespots almost never evolved directly. Skates, for instance, first gained basic markings that later evolved into concentric-ring eyespots. Smaller species without “weapons” were much more likely to develop bold spots if they lived in well-lit, shallow waters less than 200 metres deep, the paper said.

“Eyespots ... tend to evolve in species that lack strong physical defences, such as venomous tail stings or electric shocks, and that live in bright, shallow waters where visual signals are effective,” said Prof. Fitzpatrick. Eyespots “are one solution among many in the evolutionary arms race between predator and prey,” per lead author Prof. Åkerman.

Eyespots are far from random. “They tend to evolve in species that lack strong physical defences, such as venomous tail stings or electric shocks, and that live in bright, shallow waters where visual signals are effective,” according to Prof. Fitzpatrick.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Value of Iran's national rial currency against one U.S. dollar

1.8 million. Iran's national rial currency hit a record high on Wednesday of 1.8 million to \$1 as ceasefire with the U.S. and Israel still holds. The rial remained stable for weeks during the war, which began on February 28, in part because there was little trading or imports coming into the country. PTI

Cameras installed at 585 locations along border belt in Punjab

2,290 Punjab Police is strengthening the "second line of defence", a deep, technology-driven security grid designed to choke the lifelines of organised crime networks operating with cross-border linkages, an official statement said. PTI

Persons arrested in Iran since the West Asia war began

4,000 Iran has executed at least 21 people and has arrested more than 4,000 since the war began, the UN said. Since the U.S.-Israeli strikes sparked the war in late February, at least nine people have been executed. PTI

The estimated cost of the Iran war for the U.S. so far

25 in \$ billion. The U.S.' war in Iran has cost \$25 billion, a senior Pentagon official said, providing the first official estimate of the military's price tag for the conflict. Jules Hurst, who is performing the duties of the comptroller, told lawmakers that most of that money was for munitions. REUTERS

Children killed in Bangladesh due to measles outbreak

227 Bangladesh has recorded 227 child deaths since March in one of its worst outbreaks of measles in decades, with the number of suspected cases reaching nearly 35,000, government data showed on Wednesday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Increasing coverage, growing distress

Rising insurance coverage has not increased hospitalisation or reduced out-of-pocket expenditure, as more people shift to private sector care with higher costs; govt.-funded health insurance schemes are failing to protect households from financial hardship while disproportionately benefiting the better-off

ECONOMIC NOTES

Indranil Montu Bose

The latest NSS data of the 80th round on "Household Social Consumption: Health" reveals several concerning results that need wider discussion. The survey, conducted between January and December 2025, shows that while insurance coverage has increased considerably compared to the 2017-18 (75th round), this has not translated into a significant rise in the utilisation of hospital care. A greater proportion of people are now going to the private sector. Meanwhile, out-of-pocket (OOP) expenditure on hospitalisation has risen sharply between 2017-18 and 2025, particularly in the private sector.

Coverage without care
Currently, 47.4% of rural households and 44.3% of urban households are covered by some form of health insurance. This has been achieved mainly by more than a two-and-a-half-fold increase in coverage between 2017-18 and 2025 of government-financed health insurance (GFHI) schemes such as Prime Minister Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) and Swasthya Saathi (in West Bengal). The NSS definition of GFHI also includes the Employees' State Insurance Scheme (ESIS), the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS), and those for State government employees, etc. However, as per official records, increased coverage of ESIS or CGHS would have very little contribution to this significant jump in coverage. In the 2017-18 round, hospitalisation rates had decreased considerably. Despite the increase in insurance coverage, the hospitalisation rate remains below 2014 levels, though it increased marginally compared to the 2017-18 rate in rural areas. In urban areas, the rate has declined further (Figure 1).

A persistent gap

Latest NSS data* reveal limited gains in hospital use and rising expenses despite a surge in insurance schemes

Table 1: Hospitalisation cases (per 1,000 persons)

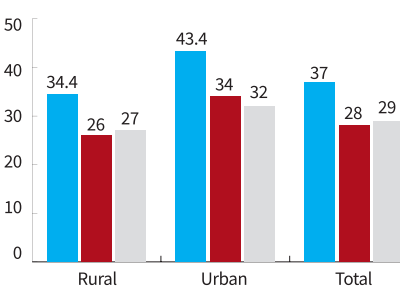
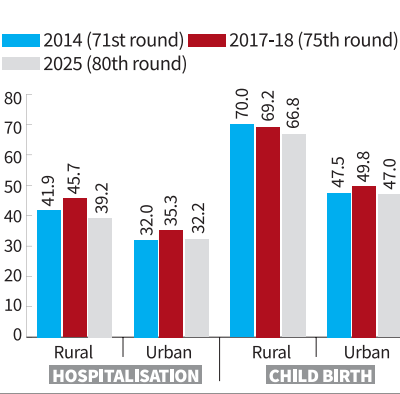


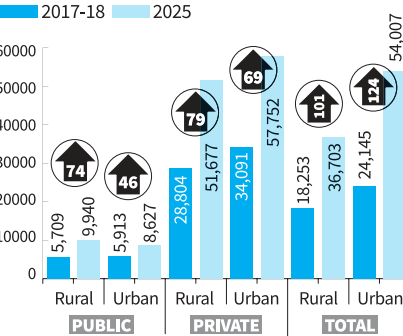
Table 2: Share (per cent) of public sector in total hospitalised episodes and child birth



Shift to private care

Between 2017-18 and 2025, there has been a considerable reduction in the use of public institutions for hospitalisation and childbirth. More people are opting for private care. There was a rise in the use of public services between 2014 and 2017-18. For non-hospitalisation care, public sector usage has increased slightly in rural areas but declined in urban areas (Figure 2). Increased access to insurance coverage is failing to protect people from financial hardship. OOP expenditure on hospitalisation has more than doubled in both rural and urban areas between

Table 3: Average OOP on hospitalisation (₹): 2017-18 and 2025 by location and facility type (growth rate in % within arrow)



SOURCE: AUTHORS' ESTIMATES FROM UNIT RECORDS OF VARIOUS NSS SOCIAL CONSUMPTION: HEALTH ROUNDS

2017-18 and 2025. Even in public hospitals, patients incur significant expenses due to the unavailability of medicines, diagnostic services, and high transport and other non-medical costs. As expected, when people seek care in the private sector, they incur very high costs. Average hospitalisation expenses in private hospitals have increased by 70% in rural areas and 80% in urban areas (Figure 3). GFHI schemes such as PMJAY are meant to cover high-cost, low-frequency hospitalisation needs for enrolled households. Care can be sought in empanelled public and private facilities, and these schemes are promoted as offering free treatment in private hospitals. Public hospitals are, anyway, largely subsidised and should be either free or more affordable. Of the people enrolled under the GFHIs and needing hospitalisation, 57% sought care in private hospitals. Very few got free care, as promised under these schemes. The average OOP expenditure (excluding childbirth) is ₹31,250 in rural areas and ₹34,259 in urban areas. Although GFHIs target socio-economically backward sections, many States have extended coverage to non-poor populations. Though there is relatively higher coverage among the poorer income groups, when it comes to

utilisation of services under these schemes, it is the relatively better off who benefit disproportionately. Data show that only 13% of those using hospitalisation services under these schemes in urban areas belong to the poorest class. The inclusion of non-poor households has also increased utilisation and placed a greater strain on States' budgets. In Haryana and West Bengal, nearly 15% of their State health budgets are spent on GFHIs. This increased fiscal strain is also leading to delays in reimbursement to private providers. Essentially, GFHIs use tax money to subsidise care for the private sector. This helps the private sector to have access to markets which were hitherto out of its reach due to low purchasing power. In India, the private sector largely functions on the principles of profit maximisation, with limited motivation for social solidarity and is essentially unregulated. Since GFHI reimbursement rates are below market rates, even though the rates are more remunerative than CGHS, patients are often charged additionally. Thus, the experience of the first seven years of PMJAY and GFHIs in general shows that these schemes are 'of the rich', 'for the profit', and 'by the poor people'. Is that a desirable consequence? It may be time to rethink the insurance-led model of Universal Health Coverage (UHC) and refocus on strengthening the public healthcare system to deliver universal, comprehensive care. In this context, Ayushman Arogya Mandir (AAM) – PMJAY's relatively neglected counterpart aimed at providing comprehensive primary care, including services for non-communicable diseases – shows a glimmer of hope. However, it remains severely underfunded, much like the National Health Mission. (Indranil is a Professor at the School of Government and Public Policy, O.P Jindal Global University. Montu Bose is an Assistant Professor at the School of Health Systems Studies, TISS, Mumbai. With CMIE data inputs from Akarsh CO, Research Associate, O.P. Jindal Global University)

THE GIST

- Increased insurance coverage has not led to a significant increase in utilisation of hospital care, with more people going to the private sector.
- Out-of-pocket expenditure on hospitalisation has seen tremendous increases, and insurance is failing to protect people from financial hardship.

Why has the creamy layer debate returned to court?

Is the current push based on a misreading of the judgment? Can income be used as a proxy?

LETTER & SPIRIT

Prannv Dhawan Vignesh Karthik K.R.

Fresh petitions before the Supreme Court are seeking to extend the creamy layer principle to SC/ST reservations, based on a misreading of the 2024 Davinder Singh judgment. The move revives a decades-old debate about whether income can serve as a proxy for caste-based disadvantage, and whether social justice can be trapped inside an economic test. The renewed push On March 10, the Supreme Court issued notice to the Centre and all States on a public interest litigation filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay seeking the exclusion of a "creamy layer" from SC/ST

reservations. A separate plea, filed in February, sought an income-based prioritisation mechanism within these quotas. Both petitions claim constitutional sanction from the same source: the seven-judge bench decision in *State of Punjab v. Davinder Singh* (2024). That judgment permitted States to sub-classify Scheduled Caste communities to direct reservation benefits toward the most marginalised within them. Four of seven judges made passing observations that creamy layer logic might apply to SC/ST groups. A doctrine born in ambiguity The creamy layer principle entered Indian constitutional law through the judgment in *Indra Sawhney v. Union of India* (1992), where the Supreme Court upheld OBC reservations but held that the more advanced sections, the "creamy layer," should be excluded from benefits. The 1993 Office Memorandum that

followed identified creamy layer exclusion primarily through status, not income. Holding a Class I or Class II post in government was the proxy, a recognition that institutional power compounds across generations. This architecture was progressively diluted. A 2004 clarificatory letter from the Department of Personnel and Training began treating PSU salaries as a standalone disqualifying criterion. On March 11, the Supreme Court in *Union of India v. Rohith Nathan* struck down that letter, holding that parental salary alone cannot determine creamy layer status. The 1993 OM's status-based logic was restored, but the deeper premise of the doctrine, that economic attainment adequately measures the erasure of social disadvantage, remained intact and unexamined. The Ambedkar objection In his 1932 note to the Lothian

Committee, B.R. Ambedkar warned that excluding wealthy or educated individuals from the category of untouchables was "a totally erroneous view." At the Mahar Conference of 1936, Ambedkar put it concretely: the educated, propertied Mahar still cannot open a shop without customers leaving when his caste is known; he still cannot apply for a job without his identity becoming a disqualification. Economic progress and social emancipation travel on different tracks, and the creamy layer doctrine collapses the two. Data presented in *Jaishri Patil v. Union of India* (2021) showed that even Group D government employees were rendered ineligible for post-matric scholarships due to income-testing. The court noted that a family earning ₹6 lakh a year cannot be equated with one earning ₹24 lakh simply because both exceed a common ceiling. Statistical research published by Nishith Prakash showed that elite capture of quota benefits was a myth. Contrary to the popular notion, the positive impact of quota policy is concentrated among 'the less-educated SC members in rural areas.' The doctrine's bluntness produces what may be called a creamy layer trap: the bar is set low enough to exclude the barely stable, yet the social burdens that reservation addresses persist regardless of salary bracket. The SC/ST distinction The case for creamy layer exclusion was

always weaker for SC/ST communities than for OBCs. Sub-classification, what Davinder Singh actually authorised, is a different instrument entirely. It asks which sub-communities within the SC list are least represented and directs preference toward them. Extending creamy layer logic to SC/ST would mean removing individuals from reservation eligibility based on parental income, precisely what Ambedkar argued was constitutionally and sociologically indefensible. Justice B.R. Gavai, who endorsed the broader principle in Davinder Singh, himself acknowledged that the criteria for SC/ST cannot be identical to those for OBCs. Parliament's moment The *Rohith Nathan* judgment creates a narrow but real opportunity for legislative recalibration, one that measures social backwardness by the subordination they continue to face. Parliament has both the constitutional authority and the democratic obligation to clarify that sub-classification and creamy layer exclusion are distinct instruments, and that the latter has no application to communities whose inclusion in the Presidential list was never conditioned on poverty. (Prannv Dhawan is an LLM Candidate at Yale Law School. Vignesh Karthik KR is a postdoctoral research affiliate at the Royal Netherlands Institute of Southeast Asian and Caribbean Studies, Leiden)

